

TCM Basics

The Four Natures

Nature	Thermal tendency	Actions	Used for	Caution
Hot	Very warming	Strongly warms interior, rescues yang, disperses cold	Cold pain, cold limbs, severe yang deficiency	Heat patterns, yin deficiency with heat
Warm	Warming	Warms middle, disperses cold, assists yang, circulates qi	Spleen-stomach cold, cold-type pain, qi deficiency with cold	Yin deficiency, heat signs, sore throat
Neutral	Balanced	Tonifies gently, harmonizes, neither heats nor cools	General nourishment; most constitutions; long-term use	Few contraindications ; still watch quantity
Cool	Cooling	Clears heat, generates fluids, nourishes yin lightly	Heat patterns, summerheat, dry mouth, mild fever	Spleen-stomach deficiency-cold, loose stools
Cold	Strongly cooling	Clears heat and fire, detoxifies, purges heat	High fever, intense thirst, sores, summerheat stroke	Yang deficiency, cold constitution, pregnant women (some)

Therapeutic rule: "Treat cold with heat; treat heat with cold". Cold/cool foods relieve heat syndromes; warm/hot foods relieve cold syndromes. Overuse of any thermal extreme damages the spleen-stomach.

The Five Flavors

Flavor	Organ affinity	Primary actions	Indications	Excess harms
Sour (+ astringent)	Liver	Astringes/consolidates (stops sweating, diarrhea, seminal emission); generates fluids	Sweating, chronic diarrhea, cough, thirst, leakage of essence	Contracts evil qi; avoid in excess pathogens, constipation
Bitter	Heart	Drains heat, dries dampness, descends qi, hardens yin	Heat, fire, damp-heat, cough with rebellious qi, constipation	Over-dries; damages yin and fluids; injures spleen
Sweet	Spleen	Tonifies/supplements, harmonizes, relaxes tension, moistens	Deficiency, weakness, pain/spasm, dryness; harmonizes other foods	Produces dampness; bloats; avoid in damp/phlegm, diabetes (use care)
Pungent	Lung	Disperses, moves qi and blood, opens the exterior, resolves stagnation	Exterior cold/flu, qi stagnation, blood stasis, bloating	Scatters qi; overuse injures qi and yin; caution with heat
Salty	Kidney	Softens hardness, dissolves nodules, purges downward	Nodules, lumps, constipation (e.g., kelp, seaweed)	Overuse harms blood; caution with hypertension/edema

Meridian Tropism

Meridian tropism records which organ-channel network a food primarily acts upon, explaining why seemingly similar foods target different complaints — e.g., pear (Lung) for cough vs. hawthorn (Spleen/Stomach/Liver) for meat stagnation. Common channels in food therapy: Lung, Spleen, Stomach, Heart, Liver, Kidney, Large Intestine, Small Intestine, Bladder.

The Five Colors

Color	Element	Organs	Core dietary action
Red	Fire	Heart; Small Intestine	Nourishes blood, invigorates circulation, supports the heart and spirit
Green	Wood	Liver; Gallbladder	Soothes liver qi, clears heat, resolves toxins, moves the bowels
Yellow	Earth	Spleen; Stomach	Tonifies spleen-stomach, aids digestion, supplements qi and blood, slows aging
White	Metal	Lung; Large Intestine	Moistens lung, generates fluids, boosts defensive qi, lubricates intestines
Black/Purple	Water	Kidney; Bladder	Tonifies kidney and yin, enriches essence/blood, drains dampness, prolongs life

Food Pairing & Compatibility

Synergy. Foods are combined to reinforce effects or protect the digestion: mutual accentuation (two foods sharing a goal — e.g., pear + rock sugar for lung-dry cough); assistance (a food offsets a side effect — ginger with cold crab); and pairing with a carrier (brown sugar, honey, or rice porridge harmonizes delivery). Classic simple pairings appear in every entry below.

Incompatibilities & taboos. Traditional food-therapy records flag combinations believed to burden digestion or provoke patterns (e.g., persimmon with crab, sweet potato or wine — cold astringent meeting cold protein/starch risks gastric bezoar; honey with scallion; watermelon with oily foods). Modern evidence varies, but the enduring principle is sound: match food to the constitution — cold-natured foods for heat patterns and hot constitutions are fine, but the same foods worsen spleen-stomach deficiency-cold (loose stools, cold limbs, poor appetite); warm-natured foods help cold patterns but aggravate heat signs (mouth ulcers, sore throat, constipation).

Red

Jujube / Red Date

红枣

Red Warm · Sweet Spleen · Stomach · Heart

Effects

- Tonifies the middle burner and augments qi (补中益气)
- Nourishes blood and calms the spirit (养血安神)
- Moderates/harmonizes the harsh properties of other foods and herbs

Indications

Spleen-stomach weakness with fatigue and poor appetite; qi and blood deficiency (pale face, anemia); heart-blood deficiency insomnia, palpitations, restless agitation; postpartum weakness; women's emotional lability.

Beneficial pairings

- + black fungus, simmered in soup — nourishes blood for anemia and sallow complexion
- + longan + lotus seed — heart-blood deficiency insomnia and forgetfulness
- + fresh ginger — warms the middle for cold-stomach discomfort
- + glutinous rice or millet congee — gentle daily tonic for weak digestion

Cautions & incompatibilities

Warm and cloyingly sweet — generates dampness and heat; avoid or reduce with abdominal bloating/fullness, damp-heat, thick greasy tongue coating, phlegm, dental disease/caries, and diabetes (high sugar). Not for acute fever or excess heat.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: qi-blood deficiency, anemia, cold-weak digestion, insomnia from blood deficiency. **Avoid/reduce:** damp-heat constitution, bloating, diabetes, mouth ulcers.

Strawberry

草莓

Red Cool · Sweet, slightly sour Lung · Spleen

Effects

- Moistens the lung and generates fluids (润肺生津)
- Clears summerheat and cools blood; resolves toxin
- Fortifies the spleen and aids appetite

Indications

Wind-heat type sore throat and dry cough; summerheat thirst and irritability; poor appetite after fever; mild constipation; "internal heat" with mouth sores in spring-summer.

Beneficial pairings

- + honey, mashed — soothes dry throat and constipation
- + yogurt or milk — balances acidity, supports digestion
- + rock sugar, simmered briefly — lung-dry cough in children

Cautions & incompatibilities

Cooling — those with spleen-stomach deficiency-cold and loose stools should eat small amounts; fruit acids may irritate gastric ulcers. Contains oxalates — kidney-stone-prone people moderate. Wash well; common allergen in young children.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: heat patterns, dry mouth/throat, summer heat, sluggish bowels.

Avoid/reduce: cold-stomach loose stools, active ulcers.

Hawthorn

山楂

Red Slightly warm · Sour, sweet Spleen · Stomach · Liver

Effects

- Resolves food stagnation, especially meat and greasy-fat accumulation (消食化积)
- Moves qi and dissipates blood stasis (行气散瘀)
- Transforms turbidity and lowers lipids (化浊降脂)

Indications

Bloating, belching and abdominal pain after heavy meaty meals; diarrhea or dysentery with food stagnation; postpartum abdominal pain from stasis; amenorrhea/dysmenorrhea with stasis; modern use for hyperlipidemia.

Beneficial pairings

- + malt (sprouted barley, 麦芽) — covers both meat and grain/starch stagnation
- + brown sugar, decocted — postpartum stasis abdominal pain and menstrual pain
- + chrysanthemum / cassia seed tea — supports lipid and blood-pressure management

Cautions & incompatibilities

Very sour — erodes tooth enamel in excess (rinse mouth); contraindicated in spleen-stomach weakness without stagnation, gastric/duodenal ulcer and hyperacidity;

its blood-activating property cautions against medicinal doses in pregnancy; large amounts on an empty stomach can precipitate gastric bezoars.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: greasy-meat stagnation, bloating, high lipids, blood stasis. **Avoid/reduce:** pregnancy (large/medicinal amounts), ulcers, weak stomach without stagnation.

Waxberry / Bayberry (Yangmei)

杨梅

Red Warm · Sweet, sour Lung · Stomach

Effects

- Generates fluids and relieves thirst (生津止渴)
- Harmonizes the stomach and stops vomiting
- Astringes the intestines to check diarrhea (涩肠止泻)

Indications

Summer thirst and poor appetite; vomiting and diarrhea, including mild dysentery; hangover with dry mouth; motion sickness nausea.

Beneficial pairings

- Dipped in a little salt — enhances fluid production, reduces astringency and prevents bloating (classic way to eat)
- Steeped in liquor (杨梅酒) — cold-damp diarrhea and summer cholera-like upset
- + hawthorn — food stagnation and overindulgence

Cautions & incompatibilities

Warm and sour — excess easily generates internal heat (mouth ulcers, toothache, nosebleed tendency); heat constitutions and dental problems should moderate. Wash gently; bruised fruit ferments quickly.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: summer vomiting/diarrhea, thirst, poor appetite. **Avoid/reduce:** yin-deficiency heat, active canker sores, weak teeth.

Peach

桃子

Red Warm · Sweet, sour Liver · Large Intestine

Effects

- Nourishes yin and generates fluids (养阴生津)

- Augments qi and moistens the lung
- Activates blood and dissipates accumulation; moistens intestines to move the bowels

Indications

Dry constipation, especially in the elderly or after illness; qi-blood deficiency with pallor and fatigue; menstrual discomfort with stasis; summer thirst and dry skin.

Beneficial pairings

- + honey — dry-intestine constipation
- + rock sugar, stewed — post-illness dry cough and thirst
- Stewed with white fungus — dry skin and constipation

Cautions & incompatibilities

Warm — overeating easily produces heat and may worsen boils, sores and constipation of the heat type; unripe/hard fruit can cause diarrhea; peach-fuzz allergy is common (peel if sensitive); moderate sugar for diabetes.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: dry constipation, weak/elderly, post-illness recovery. **Avoid/reduce:** active heat/sores, allergies, diabetes (excess).

Grapefruit

葡萄柚

Red Cold · Sweet, sour Spleen · Stomach · Lung

Effects 功效

- Fortifies the stomach and resolves food stagnation (健胃消食)
- Transforms phlegm and stops cough; moves chest qi
- Relieves alcohol toxin

Indications

Indigestion and bloating after greasy meals; cough with profuse phlegm; hangover; overeating with chest fullness; thirst in heat patterns.

Beneficial pairings

- + honey — phlegm-type cough and dry throat
- Eaten after rich meals — relieves greasy stagnation
- Peel simmered with chicken — bloating and phlegm-dampness

Cautions & incompatibilities

Cold — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold with loose stools should eat little or warm it.
Modern drug interaction: grapefruit (and pomelo) furanocoumarins interact with many prescription medicines (statins, calcium-channel blockers, etc.) — check with a pharmacist. Not for diarrhea.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: phlegm-dampness, overeating, heat constitutions. **Avoid/reduce:** cold-stomach diarrhea; those on interacting medications.

Watermelon

西瓜

Red Cold · Sweet Heart · Stomach · Bladder

Effects 功效

- Clears summerheat and generates fluids (清热解暑) — called "nature's White Tiger Decoction" (天生白虎汤)
- Relieves irritability and stops thirst
- Promotes urination; the rind (西瓜翠衣) clears heat and reduces edema

Indications

Summerheat stroke with high fever, profuse thirst and scanty dark urine; mouth and tongue ulcers; summer edema; irritability from heat.

Beneficial pairings

- + mung bean soup — intense summerheat and thirst
- Fresh rind decocted with a little rock sugar — summer edema and scanty urine
- + tomato juice — summer appetite loss and thirst

Cautions & incompatibilities

One of the coldest foods — strictly moderate in spleen-stomach deficiency-cold, chronic loose stools, cold limbs, postpartum recovery, and the frail elderly; avoid with greasy/iced foods; high sugar for diabetes.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: summerheat, heat patterns, fever-thirst, heat edema. **Avoid/reduce:** cold-stomach diarrhea, yang deficiency, postpartum, diabetes (excess).

Persimmon

柿子

Red Cold · Sweet, astringent Heart · Lung · Large Intestine

Effects

- Clears heat and moistens the lung (清热润肺)
- Generates fluids and stops thirst; astringes the intestines
- Transforms phlegm and softens hardness; persimmon frost (柿霜) treats mouth sores

Indications

Lung-dry cough with scant sticky sputum; dry throat and thirst; hemorrhoid bleeding; chronic diarrhea (astringent action); mouth ulcers (persimmon frost).

Beneficial pairings

- + rock sugar, stewed — lung-dry cough and throat dryness
- Dried persimmon (柿饼) + rice congee — chronic spleen-cold diarrhea (use small amounts)

Cautions & incompatibilities

Classic incompatibility: **do not eat with crab** (both cold; tannin + protein causes stomach pain, vomiting, diarrhea), **not with sweet potato** (tannin + starch promotes gastric bezoar), not with wine, and never on an empty stomach or unripe — tannins can form persimmon bezoars (胃柿石). Cold nature — spleen deficiency, diabetes and postpartum avoid.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: heat constitutions, dry cough, hemorrhoid bleeding (ripe, small amounts).

Avoid/reduce: cold stomach, empty-stomach eating, crab/sweet potato combos, diabetes.

Cherry

樱桃

Red Warm · Sweet Spleen · Liver

Effects

- Tonifies the middle burner and augments qi (补中益气)
- Dispels wind and eliminates dampness; relieves bi-syndrome joint pain
- Promotes rash expression; used externally for frostbite

Indications

Fatigue and poor appetite from spleen weakness; wind-damp joint and limb pain with numbness; measles where the rash fails to express; mild frostbite (cherry liquor rubbed on).

Beneficial pairings

- Cherry steeped in liquor (樱桃酒) — rheumatism-type joint pain and frostbite

- + longan — qi-blood deficiency and fatigue
- + brown sugar, stewed — weakness after illness

Cautions & incompatibilities

Warm — overeating strongly generates internal heat ("cherries kindle fire"); reduce or avoid fever, heat-type cough, canker sores, constipation, nosebleed tendency, and asthma flares. Pit contains cyanogenic compounds — do not chew/crush pits.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: cold-damp joint pain, qi deficiency, frostbite (external). **Avoid/reduce:** heat signs, fever, acute cough, yin deficiency.

Lychee

荔枝

Red Warm · Sweet, slightly sour Heart · Spleen · Liver

Effects 功效

- Nourishes blood and fortifies the spleen (养血健脾)
- Moves qi and reduces swelling; warms the middle
- Benefits the heart spirit and generates fluids

Indications

Blood deficiency with palpitations and insomnia; spleen-deficiency diarrhea and stomach pain; post-illness fluid deficiency with hiccup and thirst; scrofula and boils (folk use).

Beneficial pairings

- + red jujube + longan — heart-blood deficiency insomnia and forgetfulness
- Dried lychee congee with lotus seed — spleen-deficiency morning diarrhea
- + rice wine, stewed — postpartum cold pain and weakness

Cautions & incompatibilities

Warm and sweet — excess causes "lychee sickness" (hypoglycemia in children gorging on fruit) and strong heat signs (mouth ulcers, sore throat, nosebleed). Avoid yin-deficiency heat, during fever/flu; diabetics note high sugar despite the hypoglycemia paradox — eat small amounts.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: cold constitutions, blood deficiency, postpartum (moderate). **Avoid/reduce:** heat/yin-deficiency, fever, children eating excess.

Pomegranate

石榴

Red Warm · Sweet, sour, astringent Lung · Kidney · Large Intestine

Effects

- Generates fluids and stops thirst (生津止渴)
- Astringes the intestines to check chronic diarrhea and dysentery
- The peel (石榴皮) is a strong astringent-astringent medicine; anthelmintic use recorded

Indications

Chronic diarrhea and dysentery, rectal prolapse; blood in stool/hemorrhoids; dry throat and thirst in summer; chronic cough with leakage patterns.

Beneficial pairings

- Peel decocted with ginger/brown sugar — persistent cold-diarrhea (medicinal use)
- Fresh juice + a little honey — thirst and dry throat
- + smoked plum (wumei) — chronic diarrhea and sweats

Cautions & incompatibilities

Astringent — do not use in constipation or in the early stage of dysentery/cough when an exterior pathogen is still present (astringing traps the pathogen). Warm and sour — heat signs, excess stomach acid and weak teeth moderate; juice stains; moderate sugar for diabetes.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: chronic diarrhea/leakage, summer thirst. **Avoid/reduce:** constipation, acute dysentery, acid excess, heat signs.

Tomato

番茄

Red Slightly cold · Sweet, sour Liver · Spleen · Stomach

Effects

- Generates fluids and stops thirst; fortifies the stomach and resolves stagnation
- Cools blood and pacifies the liver (凉血平肝)
- Clears heat and resolves toxin

Indications

Thirst and poor appetite in summer; indigestion after greasy meals; liver-yang hypertension with dizziness and red face; gum bleeding; feverish illnesses.

Beneficial pairings

- + celery juice — hypertension and liver heat
- Cooked with egg — weak digestion and poor appetite (cooking reduces coldness)
- + kelp soup — blood-pressure and lipid support

Cautions & incompatibilities

Slightly cold — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold with loose stools should eat it cooked, not raw in quantity; unripe green tomatoes contain solanine — do not eat; oxalate content — kidney-stone-prone moderate.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: heat patterns, hypertension, overeating, summer thirst. **Avoid/reduce:** cold-stomach diarrhea (eat cooked), green unripe fruit.

Sweet Potato

红薯

Red Neutral · Sweet Spleen · Stomach · Kidney · Large Intestine

Effects

- Tonifies the middle and harmonizes blood (补中和血)
- Augments qi and generates fluids
- Loosens the intestines and moves the bowels (宽肠通便)

Indications

Chronic dry constipation, especially in the elderly and postpartum; spleen deficiency with edema and weakness; post-illness thinness; dry stools with difficulty.

Beneficial pairings

- + rice/millet congee — weak digestion and constipation
- + ginger, steamed — reduces bloating and cold discomfort
- + lotus seed/yam — spleen deficiency loose stools (well-cooked)

Cautions & incompatibilities

Sweet and starchy — causes acid reflux and gas in excess; eat fully cooked and moderate with gastric ulcers/reflux. Classic caution: separate from persimmon by several hours (starch + tannin bezoar risk). Moldy/black-spotted sweet potatoes are toxic — discard. Diabetes counts it as staple.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: dry constipation, weak elderly, post-illness. **Avoid/reduce:** reflux/bloating, persimmon meals, moldy tuber, diabetes (as staple substitute).

Carrot

胡萝卜

Red Neutral · Sweet Lung · Spleen

Effects

- Fortifies the spleen and harmonizes the middle (健脾和中)
- Nourishes the liver and brightens the eyes (滋肝明目)
- Transforms phlegm, stops cough; clears heat and resolves toxin

Indications

Night blindness and dry eyes (eye strain, screen use); childhood indigestion and weak appetite; measles promotion (with coriander); dry cough; constipation from dryness.

Beneficial pairings

- + lamb, slow-stewed — classic winter tonic for cold-weak constitution and blood deficiency
- + coriander (cilantro) — promotes measles rash
- + rice congee — eye health and weak digestion in children

Cautions & incompatibilities

Very safe; very large daily intake can cause benign carotenemic yellowing of skin (reversible). Folk note that carrot enzymes degrade white-radish vitamin C when raw-mixed — negligible with normal cooking. No major contraindications.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: eye fatigue/dryness, weak digestion, children, winter stews. **Avoid/reduce:** few; moderate in carotenemia.

Chili Pepper

辣椒

Red Hot · Pungent Heart · Spleen

Effects

- Warms the middle and disperses cold (温中散寒)
- Induces sweating and expels cold-dampness
- Opens the appetite and resolves food stagnation

Indications

Cold-type stomach pain with preference for warmth; cold-damp vomiting and diarrhea; poor appetite in damp-cold weather; cold-damp joint pain; frostbite (tincture, external).

Beneficial pairings

- + fresh ginger + brown sugar — cold-stomach pain and early wind-cold exposure
- + garlic — cold-damp diarrhea and dysentery patterns
- Cooked with rich meats — cuts greasiness and stimulates digestion

Cautions & incompatibilities

One of the hottest foods — strongly generates fire. Avoid with mouth/tongue ulcers, sore throat, hemorrhoids, gastritis/ulcer, inflammatory bowel disease, hypertension, eye disease, constipation, yin-deficiency heat, and in pregnancy excess. May worsen flushing and sleep.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: cold-damp constitutions, cold stomach, frostbelt climates. **Avoid/reduce:** any heat sign, ulcers, hemorrhoids, hypertension, inflamed gut.

Green

Kiwifruit

猕猴桃

Green Cold · Sweet, sour Spleen · Stomach · Kidney

Effects

- Clears heat and generates fluids (清热生津)
- Fortifies the spleen and stops diarrhea
- Relieves stranguria and reduces stone formation; modern use for constipation and dyspepsia

Indications

Dry constipation and intestinal dryness; heat-damp urinary difficulty/stranguria; indigestion and poor appetite; fever with thirst; hyperlipidemia support.

Beneficial pairings

- + honey — dry constipation and dry throat
- + yogurt — heat-type sluggish digestion
- + aloe jelly (folk) — constipation

Cautions & incompatibilities

Cold — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold with loose stools and frequent urination should avoid or cook; fruit acids irritate ulcers; some sources note caution with dairy for sensitive digestion; possible allergy in children.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: heat constipation, urinary heat, overeating. **Avoid/reduce:** cold diarrhea, yang deficiency, ulcers.

Chinese Olive

橄榄

Green Neutral (warm-cooked) · Sweet, sour, astringent Lung · Stomach

Effects

- Clears lung-heat and benefits the throat (清肺利咽) — a classic sore-throat and fish-bone food
- Generates fluids and resolves toxin; promotes appetite
- Resolves alcohol and fish-crab poisoning

Indications

Sore, swollen throat and hoarseness (chronic pharyngitis); thirst and bad breath; ingestion of fish bones/seafood toxin; hangover.

Beneficial pairings

- + fresh radish juice — epidemic sore throat and diphtheria-pattern swelling (classic folk remedy)
- Stewed with pork lung — dry cough and throat dryness
- Preserved olives (青果) steeped as tea — chronic pharyngitis

Cautions & incompatibilities

Generally safe; astringent-sour, so excessive raw intake may constipate; warm the fruit for very cold stomachs. Pit is not eaten.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: sore throat, dry mouth, smokers, seafood meals. **Avoid/reduce:** constipation excess, extreme cold stomach (cook it).

Smoked Plum

梅子 / 乌梅

Green Neutral (processed warm) · Sour, astringent Liver · Spleen · Lung · Large Intestine

Effects

- Astringes the lung and intestine (敛肺涩肠) — chronic cough and chronic diarrhea
- Generates fluids and relieves thirst (生津止渴) — the classic "Wangmei quke" plum-drink
- Expels roundworms (安蛔) and relieves parasitic abdominal pain

Indications

Summer heat-damaged fluids with thirst; chronic dry cough; chronic diarrhea/dysentery; biliary ascariasis pain; irritability and poor appetite (sour-plum drink 酸梅汤).

Beneficial pairings

- + hawthorn + licorice + osmanthus, brewed as sour-plum drink — summerheat thirst and digestion
- + smoked plum rice congee — chronic diarrhea
- + rice vinegar — biliary worm pain (folk medicinal use)

Cautions & incompatibilities

Astringent — contraindicated in exterior syndrome (colds/flu), excess heat, and constipation; sour erodes teeth in excess; raw unripe plums are very acidic and damaging — eat small amounts or processed; excess stomach acid avoid.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: summer thirst (as wumei tang), chronic diarrhea/dry cough, ascariasis.

Avoid/reduce: active colds, constipation, ulcers/hyperacidity.

Muskmelon / Sweet Melon

香瓜

Green Cold · Sweet Stomach · Lung · Large Intestine

Effects

- Clears summerheat and relieves irritability (清暑热)
- Generates fluids, quenches thirst, promotes urination
- The seed (甜瓜子) clears lung heat and expels intestinal pus/abscess patterns

Indications

Summerheat stroke with thirst and scanty urine; mouth and tongue sores; hot-type urinary difficulty; summer diarrhea with heat.

Beneficial pairings

- + watermelon — intense summer heat
- + cucumber, as salad — heat edema

Cautions & incompatibilities

Cold — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold, chronic enteritis with loose stools, postpartum and menstruating women should avoid excess; not with very greasy foods (double cold causes diarrhea); diabetics note sugar.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: summerheat, heat edema, heat constitutions. **Avoid/reduce:** cold stomach, loose stools, postpartum.

Cilantro / Coriander

香菜 / 芫荽

Green Warm · Pungent Lung · Stomach

Effects

- Releases the exterior and induces a light sweat (发汗透疹) for wind-cold and measles
- Promotes digestion and moves qi; descends qi
- Detoxifies; used externally for rash suppression and swellings

Indications

Early wind-cold common cold; measles/chickenpox with rash not fully expressed (cilantro wash); food stagnation and bloating; fish-poisoning patterns.

Beneficial pairings

- + fresh ginger, decocted — early wind-cold with no sweat
- Boiled cilantro steam/wash — promotes measles rash in children
- + clams/clam soup — stimulates appetite; cilantro offsets seafood toxin

Cautions & incompatibilities

Warm and pungent — pungent-dispersing, so avoid/reduce in qi deficiency with spontaneous sweating, bad breath, body odor (狐臭), severe stomach ulcers, and measles that is already fully expressed (over-dispersing); allergic dermatitis history.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: early wind-cold, rash-suppression, cold-stomach bloating. **Avoid/reduce:** qi deficiency sweats, heat sores, odor complaints, allergies.

Chinese Toon Shoots

香椿

Green Neutral · Bitter, astringent Lung · Stomach · Large Intestine

Effects

- Dries dampness and clears heat (清热燥湿); detoxifies
- Kills parasites; used for intestinal worms and scabies
- Astringes; stops dysentery and vaginal discharge patterns

Indications

Dysentery and damp-heat diarrhea; skin sores and scabies (externally); vaginal discharge; hair-lustre folk use; spring seasonal "toon buds" for yang rising.

Beneficial pairings

- + egg, stir-fried — classic spring dish; clears heat and nourishes
- Blanched, then with tofu — damp-heat and appetite
- Fresh shoots, decocted/washed externally — scabies and sores

Cautions & incompatibilities

High in nitrates/nitrites — blanch in boiling water before eating and use the tender spring shoots only; old shoots and chronic kidney patients should avoid; it is a "fatty/hair-raising" food (发物) — chronic skin disease and allergy sufferers moderate.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: spring damp-heat, dysentery, appetite. **Avoid/reduce:** unblanched shoots, skin disease history, kidney disease.

Bottle Gourd

瓠瓜 / 葫芦瓜

Green Cool · Sweet Lung · Stomach · Small Intestine

Effects

- Clears heat and promotes urination (清热利水)
- Relieves irritability and quenches thirst; reduces edema
- Assists jaundice patterns (damp-heat)

Indications

Edema and ascites; heat-type painful urination; summer thirst and irritability; damp-heat jaundice; mouth sores.

Beneficial pairings

- + winter melon, stewed — edema and summer heat
- + carp soup — pregnancy/weak-person edema

Cautions & incompatibilities

Bitter fruits contain cucurbitacin toxins — never eat a bitter-tasting bottle gourd (causes severe gastroenteritis). Cool nature — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold and loose stools moderate/cook.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: edema, urinary heat, summer heat. **Avoid/reduce:** bitter fruit (toxic), cold-stomach diarrhea.

Bitter Melon

苦瓜

Green Cold · Bitter Spleen · Stomach · Heart · Liver

Effects

- Clears heat and detoxifies (清热解毒) — "gentleman's vegetable" (never passes bitterness to foods cooked with it)
- Clears heart fire and brightens the eyes (清心明目)
- Cools blood; modern use supports blood-sugar balance

Indications

Summerheat with thirst and irritability; heat-type red/painful eyes and conjunctivitis; boils and sores; dysentery; support for diabetes (weight of evidence on the seed/extract).

Beneficial pairings

- + green pepper stir-fry — the pungent disperses, reducing cold impact
- + egg — heat-type red eyes and dysentery
- Blanched briefly + salt to cut bitterness for cold-stomach people

Cautions & incompatibilities

Very cold — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold, chronic diarrhea, cold-pain abdomen, and the frail/postpartum should avoid excess or cook with ginger; pregnancy: traditionally caution large medicinal amounts (seed extract studies).

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: summer heat, red eyes, boils, heat constitutions, diabetes support.

Avoid/reduce: cold stomach, chronic diarrhea, yang deficiency.

Cucumber

黄瓜

Green Cool · Sweet Spleen · Stomach · Large Intestine

Effects

- Clears heat and promotes water metabolism (清热利水)
- Detoxifies and reduces swelling; generates fluids to quench thirst
- The juice clears heat externally — facial skin use

Indications

Summerheat thirst and sore throat; mild edema and painful urination; mouth sores; heat-type constipation; burn/scald (pulp external, folk).

Beneficial pairings

- + wood-ear mushroom stir-fry — balances blood and weight management
- + garlic dressing — offsets cucumber's coldness
- + mung bean — summer heat and boils

Cautions & incompatibilities

Cool — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold, chronic loose stools and chronic bronchitis with cold cough should eat cooked or small amounts; bitter/overripe fruit discard; raw cucumber as excess cold salad causes diarrhea.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: summer heat, edema, thirst, heat obesity. **Avoid/reduce:** cold-stomach diarrhea, cold cough.

Loofah / Silk Squash

丝瓜

Green Cool · Sweet Liver · Stomach · Lung

Effects

- Clears heat and transforms phlegm (清热化痰) — the dried vascular bundle (丝瓜络) unblocks collaterals
- Cools blood and detoxifies; the unopened flower/ovary promotes lactation
- Moves qi and unblocks channels (towel gourd sponge for wind-damp)

Indications

Heat-phlegm cough with yellow sputum; blocked lactation and breast abscess; summer boils; blood in stool/urine from heat; joint pain of wind-heat (sigaluo).

Beneficial pairings

- + egg or tofu stir-fry — heat-toxin boils and summer appetite
- Loofah + crucian carp soup — blocked lactation
- Sigaluo + rice wine decoction — breast carbuncle pain

Cautions & incompatibilities

Cool — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold with diarrhea should moderate and cook; bitter/old overgrown fruit discard; not in large amounts postpartum (cold).

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: heat-phlegm cough, lactation support, summer boils. **Avoid/reduce:** cold diarrhea, very cold constitutions.

Napa Cabbage

白菜

Green Cool (slightly cold) · Sweet Stomach · Large Intestine · Lung

Effects

- Clears stomach heat and generates fluids (清热生津)
- Nourishes the stomach, lubricates the intestines (通利肠胃)
- Detoxifies and promotes urination; "the king of vegetables" (百菜不如白菜)

Indications

Stomach heat with dry mouth and constipation; heat-type cough; sore throat; frostbite (soup external); wind-heat colds (cabbage root + scallion decoction).

Beneficial pairings

- + tofu — moistens dryness, winter nourishment (classic)
- + shrimp — balances coolness, aids calcium

- Cabbage root + scallion white + ginger — wind-cold common cold

Cautions & incompatibilities

Cool — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold, loose stools and cold chronic diarrhea should cook it; old/rotted cabbage nitrates — discard outer wilted leaves before long cooking.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: heat constipation, winter dryness, wind-heat cold. **Avoid/reduce:** cold-stomach loose stools (cook well).

Green Pepper

青椒

Green Warm (hot) · Pungent Heart · Spleen · Stomach

Effects

- Warms the middle and disperses cold (温中散寒) — the sweet/bell type is milder
- Stimulates appetite and moves qi; resolves damp
- Boosts sweating; circulates qi and blood

Indications

Cold-stomach pain and poor appetite; damp-cold body heaviness; early cold exposure; wind-cold joint discomfort; the bell type for general vitamin-C nourishment.

Beneficial pairings

- + potato shreds stir-fry — qi stagnation with bloating and constipation
- + bitter melon — heat-damp summer conditions (balancing)
- + pork — cuts richness and aids digestion

Cautions & incompatibilities

Hot chili types: same cautions as chili pepper — avoid heat signs, ulcers, hemorrhoids, sore throat, hypertension; sweet bell peppers are mild and broadly safe; nightshade alkaloids minimal in ripe fruit.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for (spicy types): cold-stomach, damp-cold. **Bell type:** most people. **Avoid/reduce spicy:** heat signs, GI inflammation, hemorrhoids.

Crown Daisy Greens

茼蒿

Green Neutral (cool) · Sweet, pungent Spleen · Stomach · Lung · Liver

Effects

- Harmonizes the spleen and stomach; moves qi and transforms phlegm (和脾胃、消痰饮)
- Calms the liver and settles the spirit (安心气) — volatile oils soothe
- Promotes urination; moistens the lung

Indications

Phlegm-damp cough with chest fullness; insomnia and irritability from liver heat/stress; poor appetite and bloating; heat-type urinary difficulty; hypertension support.

Beneficial pairings

- + egg — phlegm cough and insomnia
- + fish soup — balances fish's richness, supports hypertension
- + sesame oil, quickly blanched — constipation and dryness

Cautions & incompatibilities

Fragrant pungent oils — diarrhea from spleen deficiency should moderate; cook briefly to retain properties; very few incompatibilities; slight coolness — cold-stomach people pair with garlic/ginger.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: phlegm cough, stress insomnia, hypertension, bloating. **Avoid/reduce:** spleen-deficiency diarrhea (small amounts).

Amaranth Greens

苋菜

Green/Red Cool · Sweet Large Intestine · Small Intestine

Effects

- Clears heat and detoxifies (清热明目) — brightens red, swollen eyes
- Promotes urination and lubricates the intestines; cools blood to stop dysentery bleeding
- The seeds (苋子) clear liver heat

Indications

Damp-heat dysentery with blood; heat-type constipation and painful urination; red painful eyes; sore throat and mouth ulcers; summer boils.

Beneficial pairings

- + garlic, stir-fried — offsets coolness; dysentery patterns
- + crucian carp — weak-person dysentery (folk)
- + tofu — heat constipation and dry stools

Cautions & incompatibilities

Cool and slippery (润滑) — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold with chronic diarrhea should avoid; high nitrate — cook fresh; moderate oxalates for kidney stones; folk caution with turtle (王八/鳖) as incompatible.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: damp-heat dysentery, heat constipation, red eyes. **Avoid/reduce:** cold loose stools, kidney-stone prone (moderate).

Bracken / Fiddlehead

蕨菜

Green Cold · Sweet, slightly astringent Liver · Stomach · Large Intestine

Effects

- Clears heat and moistens the intestines (清热滑肠)
- Reduces qi-downrising and transforms phlegm; the root starch (蕨粉) is nourishing-cooling
- Lowers qi and relieves damp-heat; modern caution: ptaquiloside

Indications

Heat-type constipation; damp-heat dysentery; habitual constipation; heat-type sores; bracken-root starch for fever fluid loss.

Beneficial pairings

- + garlic/chili oil dressing — reduces coldness
- Bracken + pork stir-fry — constipation and qi stagnation

Cautions & incompatibilities

Safety first: raw/undercooked bracken contains ptaquiloside, classified possibly carcinogenic with frequent heavy consumption — always blanch thoroughly in boiling water with soda/lye then soak, eat occasionally. Cold — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold and loose stools avoid; cold nature may worsen yang deficiency.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for (occasional, well-prepared): heat constipation. **Avoid/reduce:** frequent raw intake, cold-stomach diarrhea.

Bok Choy / Rape Greens

油菜

Green Cool · Pungent, sweet Liver · Lung · Spleen

Effects

- Promotes blood circulation and dissipates stasis/abscess (行瘀散血) — used for postpartum blood stasis
- Clears heat and detoxifies; reduces swelling
- Lubricates the intestines

Indications

Postpartum abdominal pain from lochia/blood stasis; sores, carbuncles and breast abscess; habitual constipation; override rapeseed oil used for burns externally (folk).

Beneficial pairings

- + mushroom — blood-stasis patterns and constipation
- + tofu — dry constipation
- Pestled fresh leaves + rapeseed oil — external for burns/carbuncles (folk)

Cautions & incompatibilities

Blood-activating and slightly cool — early pregnancy and marked bleeding tendency caution medicinal use; eye disease with cold type folk-caution; constipation-diarrhea switch people moderate; very few daily-food contraindications.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: postpartum stasis, constipation, sores. **Avoid/reduce:** early pregnancy (large medicinal amounts), cold loose stools.

Chinese Chives

韭菜

Green Warm · Pungent Liver · Stomach · Kidney

Effects

- Warms the kidney and fortifies yang (温肾壮阳) — "qiyang grass" (起阳草)
- Moves qi and warms the middle; detoxifies
- The seeds (韭菜子) are a yang tonic; leaves resolve blood stasis and stop hiccups/vomiting

Indications

Kidney-yang deficiency: cold sore back/knees, impotence, frequent urination, enuresis; hiccup and vomiting; blood stasis pain and traumatic injury; choking on fish bones (folk, chive balls); yang spring rising.

Beneficial pairings

- + egg stir-fry — kidney yang deficiency, sore back (classic)
- + walnuts — kidney yang low back pain and constipation
- + shrimp — yang deficiency and lactation support

Cautions & incompatibilities

Warm pungent — strongly "raises fire": avoid in yin-deficiency heat, sores/boils, stomach ulcer/heat, eye disease redness, and after illness with heat; moderate in summer; classic incompatibility with honey (food-therapy records flag diarrhea) and with beef is folk-flagged; cooked leftovers produce nitrites — eat fresh.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: kidney-yang deficiency, cold back/knees, spring yang rising. **Avoid/reduce:** yin deficiency, heat sores, eye inflammation, ulcers.

Spinach

菠菜

Green Cool · Sweet Large Intestine · Stomach · Liver

Effects

- Nourishes blood and stops bleeding (养血止血) — for blood deficiency and bleeding
- Nourishes yin and pacifies the liver; moistens dryness
- Lubricates the intestines to move the bowels (润肠通便)

Indications

Blood deficiency with dizziness and pale face (iron-rich); chronic constipation and hemorrhoid bleeding; liver-wind hypertension/dizziness; nose and gum bleeding; dry thirst.

Beneficial pairings

- + pork liver soup — blood-deficiency anemia and blurred vision
- + sesame oil/peanuts — chronic constipation
- Blanched + tofu (modern view) — after blanching removes oxalate, calcium pairing safe

Cautions & incompatibilities

High oxalic acid — blanch before cooking; kidney-stone-prone and gout moderate; folk records flag spinach + tofu as binding (solvable by blanching); cool/slippery — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold with loose stools and nephritis moderate.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: anemia/bleeding, constipation, hypertension dizziness. **Avoid/reduce:** kidney stones/gout (blanch first), cold loose stools.

Celery

芹菜

Green Cool · Sweet, slightly bitter Liver · Stomach · Lung

Effects

- Pacifies the liver and clears heat (平肝清热) — hypertension headliner
- Cools blood, stops bleeding; promotes urination
- Dispels wind and dampness; calms irritability; modern: lowers blood pressure and lipids

Indications

Liver-yang/liver-fire hypertension with headache, dizziness, flushed face, tinnitus; blood in urine/carbuncles; jaundice; red eyes; menstrual heat bleeding; irritability insomnia.

Beneficial pairings

- + tomato juice — hypertension and red eyes
- + lily bulb — lung-heat cough and stress insomnia
- + lotus root juice — blood-heat nosebleed

Cautions & incompatibilities

Cool — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold, chronic diarrhea and low blood pressure should moderate/cook; sperm-damaging folklore is not evidence-based but long-term very large raw juice not advised; pregnancy moderate large medicinal amounts.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: hypertension, liver fire, headache/red eyes, hyperlipidemia. **Avoid/reduce:** cold stomach, loose stools, hypotension.

Water Spinach / Kangkung

空心菜

Green Cold · Sweet Intestine · Stomach

Effects

- Clears heat and cools blood (清热凉血)
- Detoxifies; promotes urination and lubricates the intestines
- Used for food poisoning and external sores in folk practice

Indications

Heat-type constipation and hemorrhoid bleeding; nosebleed from blood heat; summer sores and boils; urinary heat; turbid/leukorrheic discharge; external use for snake/insect bites (folk).

Beneficial pairings

- + garlic stir-fry — offsets coldness, heat dysentery
- + rice congee — heat constipation in the elderly
- Fresh juice + honey — nosebleed and hemorrhoid bleeding

Cautions & incompatibilities

Cold and slippery — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold, chronic diarrhea and low blood pressure moderate; high nitrate — cook fresh and avoid leftover reheated greens; folk incompatibility with milk/cheese (digestive upset).

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: heat constipation, hemorrhoid bleeding, summer boils. **Avoid/reduce:** cold loose stools, yang deficiency, hypotension.

White

Pear

梨

White Cool · Sweet, slightly sour Lung · Stomach

Effects

- Moistens the lung and transforms phlegm (润肺化痰)
- Generates fluids and clears heat (生津清热); relieves irritability
- Lubricates the intestines; resolves alcohol toxin

Indications

Autumn lung-dryness: dry cough with scant sticky sputum, dry throat; fever-damage fluids with thirst; heat-type constipation; hoarseness; mild alcohol hangover.

Beneficial pairings

- Stewed pear + rock sugar (冰糖炖梨) — the classic lung-dry cough remedy; reduces the raw coldness
- Pear + Sichuan fritillary bulb (川贝母) — chronic dry cough (medicinal)
- + honey — dry cough and constipation
- + water chestnut / lotus root juice — fever fluids damage

Cautions & incompatibilities

Cool — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold with loose stools, blood deficiency with cold limbs should eat it steamed/stewed, not raw; wind-cold cough with clear white sputum is worsened by raw pear; moderate sugar for diabetes.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: lung-dry cough, dry throat, autumn dryness, heat constipation.

Avoid/reduce: cold-stomach loose stools (stew it), wind-cold cough.

Apple

苹果

White/Green Cool · Sweet, slightly sour Spleen · Stomach · Lung

Effects

- Benefits the stomach and generates fluids (益胃生津)
- Moistens the lung and relieves irritability; the astringent-tannin fruit relieves mild diarrhea when cooked
- Regulates bowel function in both directions; modern: cardiovascular support

Indications

Post-illness poor appetite and dry mouth; mild diarrhea (steamed apple, pectin binds) and mild constipation (raw apple); summer diarrhea; motion-sickness nausea; weight/cardio care.

Beneficial pairings

- Steamed apple with rock sugar — mild diarrhea and weak stomach
- + hawthorn — food stagnation and indigestion
- + red jujube congee — post-illness qi deficiency

Cautions & incompatibilities

One of the safest fruits; cool — very cold stomachs can steam; wax-treated polished fruit wash well; chew thoroughly for reflux; moderate sugar for diabetes (count as fruit exchange).

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: nearly everyone; mild bowel irregularity, post-illness. **Avoid/reduce:** extreme cold-stomach (cook); no major contraindication.

Coconut

椰子

White Cool (water); Neutral (flesh) · Sweet Stomach · Spleen · Large Intestine

Effects

- Coconut water: generates fluids, promotes urination, resolves summerheat; used for dehydration
- Coconut flesh: fortifies the spleen and augments qi (补脾益气); astringes to check diarrhea
- Expels intestinal parasites (flesh) and resolves toxin

Indications

Summerheat thirst and dehydration (natural ORS pattern); heat-type edema and difficult urination; spleen weakness with poor appetite and mild diarrhea; post-illness emaciation (flesh milk).

Beneficial pairings

- Coconut water + chicken stew (海南椰盅) — summer qi deficiency with appetite loss
- Coconut milk + glutinous rice congee — spleen-deficiency loose stools
- Coconut flesh + wax gourd soup — summer edema

Cautions & incompatibilities

Coconut water is cooling and diuretic — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold, frequent urination, and hyperactive bladder should moderate; high-fat flesh produces dampness — phlegm-damp and hyperlipidemia/weight watchers moderate; coconut water's potassium content calls for moderation in severe kidney disease.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: summerheat/dehydration, edema, spleen weakness (flesh). **Avoid/reduce:** cold stomach, frequent urination, phlegm-damp, severe kidney disease (water excess).

Dragon Fruit

火龙果

White (red variant) Cool · Sweet, slightly astringent Large Intestine · Lung · Stomach

Effects

- Moistens the lung and generates fluids
- Lubricates the intestines to move the bowels (润肠通便) — rich soluble fiber/seeds
- Clears heat and resolves toxin; modern weight/metabolism support

Indications

Dry constipation and sluggish bowels; heat-type dry mouth and sore throat; post-meal stagnation; modern use for blood-glucose-friendly snacking (low glycemic) and weight management.

Beneficial pairings

- + yogurt — constipation and gut comfort
- + white fungus soup — lung-dry constipation
- + honey — dry stools

Cautions & incompatibilities

Cool and fiber-rich — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold with loose stools should not eat much (may cause diarrhea); the red-flesh variety colors urine/stool red (benign, not blood); diabetics: despite low GI, moderate portions; women during menstruation excess may add cold.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: constipation, heat constitutions, weight-conscious. **Avoid/reduce:** cold loose stools, yang deficiency, menstruation excess.

Banana

香蕉

White Cold · Sweet Lung · Large Intestine

Effects

- Clears heat and moistens the intestines (清热润肠) — foremost bowel-lubricating fruit
- Moistens the lung and stops cough; generates fluids
- Soothes the spirit and helps lower qi; relaxes tension

Indications

Dry-heat constipation, especially habitual constipation and hemorrhoid pain; lung-dry cough with thirst; alcohol toxin/heat; irritability and dry mouth; hypertension support (high potassium).

Beneficial pairings

- + rock sugar, stewed — dry cough with constipation
- Banana + sesame paste — dry constipation in the elderly
- Eaten on empty stomach (mature) — habitual constipation

Cautions & incompatibilities

Cold and slippery — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold with loose stools and chronic diarrhea strictly avoid raw; unripe green bananas contain tannins and worsen constipation; kidney failure patients restrict potassium; moderate sugar for diabetes; not with sweet potato/taro excess (bloating).

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: heat constipation, hemorrhoids, hypertension, dry cough. **Avoid/reduce:** cold loose stools, kidney failure, unripe fruit.

Fig

无花果

White Neutral · Sweet Lung · Stomach · Large Intestine

Effects

- Moistens the lung and stops cough (润肺止咳); the fresh fruit clears heat
- Fortifies the spleen and opens the appetite (健脾开胃); resolves stagnation
- Resolves toxin and reduces swelling; modern: softens hemorrhoids, supports polyps

Indications

Dry cough, hoarseness and sore throat; poor appetite and indigestion; constipation and hemorrhoids; milk-thistle-pattern sores; dried fruit for qi-deficiency fatigue.

Beneficial pairings

- Dried figs + rock sugar, stewed — lung-dry cough and hoarse voice

- + rice congee — poor appetite and post-illness weakness
- + honey water — chronic constipation and hemorrhoids

Cautions & incompatibilities

Very safe; sweet and cloying in large amounts — diarrhea from spleen deficiency moderate; diabetes moderate sugar; cooked latex in unripe fruit may irritate skin/lips — eat ripe.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: dry cough, weak digestion, constipation/hemorrhoids, post-illness.

Avoid/reduce: damp-bloating excess, diabetes (excess).

Water Chestnut

荸荠

White Cold · Sweet Lung · Stomach · Lung-Wei

Effects

- Clears heat and generates fluids (清热生津); resolves phlegm-heat
- Calms liver wind and brightens the eyes; reduces jaundice
- Resolves toxin, promotes urination; anticommissural/antidysenteric folk use

Indications

Lung heat with thick yellow sputum and sore throat; fever-fluid damage with thirst; heat-type hypertension and red eyes; jaundice and heat dysentery; mouth ulcers; summerheat (juice called "snow-pear water 雪羹汤" with sea jelly).

Beneficial pairings

- + jellyfish (sea jelly) soup (雪羹汤) — phlegm-heat hypertension and constipation (classic Qing recipe)
- + pear juice — lung heat cough and dry throat
- + lotus root juice — fever fluids and bleeding

Cautions & incompatibilities

Cold — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold, blood deficiency and loose stools eat cooked/small amounts; raw water chestnut can transmit Fasciolopsis parasites — wash/peel or cook; kidney-cold frequent urination moderate.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: phlegm-heat cough, hypertension/red eyes, fever thirst. **Avoid/reduce:** cold stomach (cook), raw consumption caution (parasites).

Ginkgo Nut

银杏 / 白果

White Neutral (slightly toxic if raw) · Sweet, bitter, astringent Lung · Kidney

Effects

- Astringes the lung and stops asthma/cough (敛肺平喘) — chronic wheeze
- Astringes leakage: enuresis, frequent urination, vaginal discharge, seminal emission
- Reduces phlegm; the seed is both food and a regulated medicinal

Indications

Chronic asthma and persistent wheezing with copious sputum; enuresis and frequent urination in children; profuse vaginal discharge; seminal emission; chronic cough.

Beneficial pairings

- + chicken/braised chicken or pork — asthma and enuresis (classic stew)
- + rock sugar, steamed — chronic cough in children
- + lotus seed + yam — spleen-lung-kidney deficiency

Cautions & incompatibilities

Toxicity caution: raw/undercooked ginkgo contains ginkgotoxin (4-O-methylpyridoxine); children are especially vulnerable (as few as ~7–10 raw seeds can poison; adults 30–40). **Always cook well and limit amounts (children a few pieces).** Do not eat the germ in excess; contraindicated in cough from exterior pathogen (astringent traps it), and in excess evil qi.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for (cooked, limited): chronic asthma/wheeze, enuresis, discharge.

Avoid/reduce: raw seed, young children in quantity, acute exterior cough.

Lotus Seed

莲子

White Neutral · Sweet, astringent Spleen · Kidney · Heart

Effects

- Tonifies the spleen and checks diarrhea (补脾止泻)
- Nourishes the heart and calms the spirit (养心安神) — insomnia and palpitations
- Benefits the kidney and secures essence (益肾固精); stops leukorrhea

Indications

Spleen-deficiency chronic loose stools and poor appetite; heart-spleen deficiency insomnia, dream-disturbed sleep, forgetfulness; kidney deficiency with seminal emission, enuresis, profuse vaginal discharge; postpartum/restlessness.

Beneficial pairings

- + lily bulb + rock sugar — insomnia, palpitations, anxiety (classic calming soup)
- + longan + jujube — heart-blood deficiency and forgetfulness
- + yam congee — spleen deficiency diarrhea

Cautions & incompatibilities

Astringent — constipation, abdominal bloating from food stagnation, and exterior fever should be avoided (astringing traps pathogens); remove the bitter green germ (lotus plumule) for calming purposes or it adds cold bitterness; very safe long-term in congee.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: insomnia/anxiety, chronic loose stools, enuresis/discharge, daily congee tonic. **Avoid/reduce:** constipation, food stagnation, acute fever.

Walnut

核桃

White Warm · Sweet Kidney · Lung · Large Intestine

Effects

- Tonifies kidney yang and strengthens the lower back/knees (补肾强腰)
- Warms the lung and anchors qi to stop chronic wheezing (温肺定喘)
- Lubricates the intestines to move the bowels (润肠通便)

Indications

Kidney deficiency: sore weak lower back and knees, frequent urination, cold legs; chronic deficiency asthma and cough (kidney failing to receive qi); elderly dry constipation; brain nourishment (memory) folk tradition; stone/sand urinary gravel (walnut oil).

Beneficial pairings

- + sesame seeds, ground — dry constipation and kidney deficiency (classic)
- + apricot kernel (杏仁) + honey — chronic dry cough/wheeze
- + chives — kidney-yang low back pain

Cautions & incompatibilities

Warm, oily and fatty — avoid/reduce in yin-deficiency heat with mouth ulcers/nosebleed, phlegm-heat cough, diarrhea, and "fire" constitutions; high calorie for weight management; rancid nuts discard; gallstone/steatorrhea moderate.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: kidney yang deficiency, elderly constipation, chronic deficiency wheeze. **Avoid/reduce:** heat signs, phlegm fire, loose stools, obesity excess.

Chestnut

栗子

White/Red-brown Warm · Sweet Spleen · Stomach · Kidney

Effects

- Tonifies the kidney and strengthens the sinews/bones (补肾强筋) — "the kidney's fruit"
- Tonifies qi and fortifies the spleen; stops bleeding (salt-roasted for kidney)
- Raw chestnuts relieve leg/knee numbness in the elderly (folk)

Indications

Sore weak lower back and knees with frequent urination (kidney deficiency); spleen-stomach deficiency with poor appetite and loose stools; traumatic bleeding; children's slow walking/leg weakness.

Beneficial pairings

- + chicken, braised (栗子烧鸡) — kidney-spleen deficiency weakness
- + rice congee — chronic diarrhea from cold deficiency
- Roasted with salt — kidney cold patterns

Cautions & incompatibilities

Starchy and cloying — overeating causes bloating, fullness and constipation ("栗子多食壅气"); diabetes counts as staple; eat fully cooked (raw chestnut in small amounts only per folk custom); food stagnation and post-illness fever avoid excess.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: kidney-deficiency, low back/knees, elderly leg weakness, cold diarrhea.

Avoid/reduce: bloating/constipation tendency, diabetes (staple count), food stagnation.

Lotus Root

莲藕

White Cool raw; Neutral-warm cooked · Sweet Heart · Spleen · Stomach

Effects

- Raw: clears heat and cools blood (清热凉血), generates fluids, stops bleeding
- Cooked: nourishes the spleen and stomach, augments qi and blood (熟藕健脾养血)
- Loosens chest qi; stops diarrhea and bleeding

Indications

Raw juice: fever-fluid thirst, nosebleed/vomiting blood from blood heat, heat dysentery; cooked: spleen-stomach weakness, post-illness anemia and emaciation, blood deficiency with dryness; "lotus root powder" (藕粉) for convalescent digestion.

Beneficial pairings

- + glutinous rice, stuffed and honey-simmered (糯米藕) — blood deficiency and anemia
- + pork rib soup — post-illness recovery and lactation
- Raw juice + pear/water chestnut juice — heat bleeding and thirst

Cautions & incompatibilities

Raw is cool-cold — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold and loose stools should be cooked only; very starchy for diabetes; folk caution with black soybean and with chrysanthemum (digestive) — minor.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for (cooked): convalescence, anemia, weak digestion. **Raw juice:** heat bleeding/thirst. **Avoid/reduce:** cold loose stools (cook it), diabetes excess.

White Radish / Daikon

白萝卜

White Cool · Pungent, sweet Lung · Stomach · Lung-Wei

Effects

- Moves qi and resolves food stagnation (下气消食) — foremost "digestion" vegetable
- Transforms phlegm and stops cough (化痰止咳)
- Cools blood, stops bleeding; promotes urination; resolves toxin

Indications

Food stagnation with bloating, belching and acid reflux; phlegm-heat cough with thick sputum; constipation from qi stagnation; bleeding (juice + a little honey); gallstone/urinary stone support; smoking-related lung phlegm.

Beneficial pairings

- + fresh ginger + scallion white, decocted — early wind-cold cold with phlegm
- + honey (juice steamed) — phlegm cough
- + lamb stew — radish cools the richness, moves qi
- + green olives juice — epidemic sore throat (青龙白虎汤)

Cautions & incompatibilities

Cool and qi-dispersing — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold with loose stools and prolapse should cook and moderate; it can weaken the action of qi-tonifying herbs (classically counteracts ginseng/asragalus tonics) — avoid with tonic regimes; gassy for IBS excess.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: food stagnation/bloating, phlegm cough, overeating, winter coughs.

Avoid/reduce: qi deficiency loose stools (cook), ginseng tonic regimens.

Lily Bulb

百合

White Cold · Sweet, slightly bitter Heart · Lung

Effects

- Nourishes lung yin and clears lung heat (养阴润肺) — dry cough, hoarseness
- Clears heart heat and calms the spirit (清心安神) — anxiety, insomnia
- Cools blood, reduces sores; modern nervous-cough and menopause support

Indications

Lung-dry/yin-deficiency dry cough with scant sputum or blood-streaked sputum; insomnia, dreamfulness, anxiety and "worrying" palpitations (lily disease 百合病); post-fever irritability; menopause vexation.

Beneficial pairings

- + lotus seed + rock sugar — insomnia and anxiety (classic calming congee)
- + snow fungus + pear — autumn lung-dry cough and dry skin
- + glutinous rice congee — post-illness weakness with dry cough

Cautions & incompatibilities

Cold and moistening — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold with loose stools, dampness with poor appetite and white greasy coating should avoid excess; wind-cold cough (clear sputum) not suitable; may increase bloating in very weak digestion.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: dry cough, insomnia/anxiety, post-fever, menopause. **Avoid/reduce:** cold loose stools, wind-cold cough, heavy dampness.

Winter Melon

冬瓜

White/Green Cool · Sweet, light Lung · Large Intestine · Small Intestine · Bladder

Effects

- Clears heat and resolves phlegm (清热化痰)

- Promotes urination and reduces edema (利水消肿) — the rind is the key part
- Generates fluids; resolves summerheat; weight-friendly

Indications

Edema from any cause, including pregnancy edema and summer edema; heat-phlegm cough; heat strangury and scanty urine; summerheat thirst; obesity/damp-heat weight patterns; the seeds expel phlegm and parasites.

Beneficial pairings

- + carp (crucian) soup — edema and low-protein swelling (classic)
- + coix seed (barley) — summer damp edema and weight support
- + kelp — hypertension and phlegm-damp

Cautions & incompatibilities

Cool and strongly diuretic — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold, chronic diarrhea, and the frail/yang deficient should cook with ginger and eat moderately; not for severe kidney failure without professional advice (potassium/fluid load in very large amounts); prolonged "winter melon only" weight loss is weakening.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: edema, summerheat, phlegm-heat cough, damp-heat obesity.

Avoid/reduce: cold stomach/loose stools (cook with ginger), yang deficiency.

Taro

芋头

White Neutral · Sweet, pungent Stomach · Large Intestine

Effects

- Tonifies qi and fortifies the spleen (补气益肾)
- Resolves toxin and disperses nodules (散结解毒) — folk use for lumps and sores
- Softens hard accumulations

Indications

Spleen-stomach weakness with poor appetite; nodules/scrofula and lumps (taro paste folk use); weak digestion after illness; constipation from dryness; external use for bites/sores.

Beneficial pairings

- + pork ribs stew — qi deficiency and weakness
- Taro congee — poor appetite and post-illness
- + bamboo shoots — nodules and phlegm accumulation (folk)

Cautions & incompatibilities

Must be fully cooked — raw taro calcium oxalate crystals burn the mouth/throat; peel with gloves (oxalate skin irritation); starchy and cloying — overeating causes bloating; diabetes counts as staple; folk caution with banana (bloating) as incompatible.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: weak digestion, post-illness, nodules (folk). **Avoid/reduce:** raw/undercooked, bloating tendency, diabetes (staple count).

Cauliflower

菜花 / 花椰菜

White Neutral · Sweet Stomach · Lung · Spleen

Effects

- Fortifies the spleen and nourishes the stomach (健脾养胃)
- Nourishes the lung and generates fluids
- Clears heat and detoxifies; modern cardiovascular and antioxidant support

Indications

Weak digestion and poor appetite; lung-dry dry cough; post-illness recovery; modern use for immune support and cardiovascular health (sulforaphane).

Beneficial pairings

- + tomato stir-fry — heat detoxification, antioxidant
- + chicken/egg soup — post-illness nourishment
- + mushroom — qi tonic for fatigue

Cautions & incompatibilities

Generally safe and neutral; gas-producing for IBS — cook and moderate; goitrogenic compounds negligible with normal cooking and iodine intake; clean florets well.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: most constitutions, weak stomach, convalescence. **Avoid/reduce:** severe gas/IBS (moderate); no major contraindication.

Chinese Yam

山药

White Neutral · Sweet Spleen · Lung · Kidney

Effects

- Tonifies spleen qi and nourishes stomach yin (补脾养胃) — top digestion tonic
- Generates fluids and benefits the lung; astringes kidney essence (补肾涩精)
- Tonifies without cloying — safe long-term (staple-like)

Indications

Spleen deficiency: chronic loose stools, fatigue, poor appetite; lung deficiency chronic cough and wheeze; kidney deficiency enuresis, vaginal discharge, seminal emission; diabetes (xiao-ke) thirst support; post-illness gentle recovery.

Beneficial pairings

- + lotus seed + gorgon (芡实) + coix — the "four gentlemen congee" for spleen-damp loose stools
- + pork rib soup — qi deficiency weakness
- + honey — lung-dry cough

Cautions & incompatibilities

Very safe; moistening and astringent — excess can cause abdominal bloating/constipation in damp-fullness; raw mucilage may irritate skin (peel with gloves); diabetes counts starchy root as staple; food stagnation with thick coating avoid excess.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: qi deficiency, chronic loose stools, weak stomach, diabetes adjunct, convalescence, all ages. **Avoid/reduce:** acute food stagnation/bloating excess.

Snow Fungus (Tremella)

银耳

White Neutral · Sweet, light Lung · Stomach · Kidney

Effects

- Nourishes yin and moistens the lung (滋阴润肺) — "the poor man's bird's nest" (平民燕窝)
- Generates fluids and nourishes the stomach; moistens skin
- Nourishes kidney yin; modern immune and lipid support

Indications

Lung-dry dry cough and throat dryness in autumn; yin deficiency with dry skin and thirst; post-fever fluid damage; dry stools; beauty/nourishing soup for women; hypertension/atherosclerosis support.

Beneficial pairings

- + rock sugar + lotus seed — classic sweet soup for insomnia and lung dryness
- + pear + lily bulb — autumn dry cough
- + red jujube — qi-blood deficiency and dryness (women's tonic)

Cautions & incompatibilities

Moistening and cloying — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold with loose stools, dampness with bloating and poor appetite moderate; soak fully and simmer; never eat cooked fungus left at room temperature overnight (biogenic amine spoilage risk — classic food-poisoning warning); moldy/deteriorated fungus discard.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: yin deficiency, dry cough, dry skin, autumn dryness. **Avoid/reduce:** cold loose stools, damp bloating; never eat spoiled/overnight sweet soup.

Bamboo Shoots

竹笋

White Cold · Sweet, slightly bitter Stomach · Lung · Large Intestine

Effects

- Clears heat and resolves phlegm (清热化痰)
- Moves qi and harmonizes the stomach; lubricates the intestines
- Promotes urination; resolves toxin; weight-friendly

Indications

Phlegm-heat cough with chest fullness; food stagnation and bloating; heat-type constipation; heat strangury; post-greasy-meal discomfort; weight management.

Beneficial pairings

- + pork, braised (笋烧肉) — cuts richness, moves qi
- + ginger, parboiled — reduces coldness and oxalate
- + chicken soup — phlegm-cough convalescence

Cautions & incompatibilities

Cold and a "hair-raising/hair food" (发物) — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold, chronic diarrhea, ulcers and allergy-prone people moderate; must be parboiled to remove oxalate/astringency; kidney-stone and gout prone moderate oxalate; children and post-illness small amounts; spring shoots can itch-throat if underprepared.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: phlegm-heat, food stagnation, constipation, weight control. **Avoid/reduce:** cold stomach/loose stools, ulcers, stone/gout (parboil), allergy history.

Water Bamboo

茭白

White Cold · Sweet Liver · Spleen · Lung

Effects

- Clears heat and detoxifies (清热解毒) — drains damp-heat
- Promotes urination and relieves strangury; quenches thirst
- Lactation support; modern jaundice/hypertension adjunct

Indications

Damp-heat jaundice; heat-type urinary difficulty; heat-dysentery; insufficient lactation; summer thirst and irritability; hypertension.

Beneficial pairings

- + crucian carp soup — blocked lactation (classic)
- + celery — hypertension
- + pork — jaundice and heat (folk cooking)

Cautions & incompatibilities

Cold — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold, loose stools and kidney-cold frequent urination moderate; black-spotted galls (smut fungus) are eaten in some regions but discarded if unsound; kidney stones — moderate oxalate.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: damp-heat/jaundice, urinary heat, lactation support, hypertension.

Avoid/reduce: cold stomach/loose stools.

Onion

洋葱

White/Purple Warm · Pungent, sweet Liver · Lung · Stomach

Effects

- Moves qi and harmonizes the stomach (理气和胃); resolves food stagnation
- Disperses cold and releases the exterior; warms yang
- Resolves phlegm and toxins; modern: cardiovascular and blood-sugar support (quercetin)

Indications

Cold-stomach bloating and poor appetite; wind-cold early cold; hypertension/hyperlipidemia/coronary support; dysentery (folk); wound/healing folk external use.

Beneficial pairings

- + vinegar — hypertension and lipids (folk)
- + beef/lamb stir-fry — cold-weak constitution
- + garlic — dysentery and phlegm (pungent pair)

Cautions & incompatibilities

Pungent and warm — avoid excess with yin-deficiency heat, mouth ulcers, eye disease/inflammation, skin itches, and post-surgery recovery; raw onion irritates ulcers and IBS; gas-producing; cut/peeled onion spoils — do not store cut onion.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: cold stomach, wind-cold, hypertension/lipids, damp constitutions.

Avoid/reduce: heat signs, ulcers (raw), eye inflammation, skin disease.

Sugarcane

甘蔗

White/Purple Cold · Sweet Lung · Stomach

Effects

- Clears heat and generates fluids (清热生津) — "nature's sugar-cane syrup for autumn dryness"
- Moistens dryness and lowers qi; harmonizes the middle
- Relieves irritability and alcohol toxin

Indications

Heat-damaged fluids with intense thirst and dry mouth; lung-dry cough; post-fever fluid recovery; constipation from dryness; hangover; "reverse-flow qi" with dry vomiting.

Beneficial pairings

- Sugarcane juice + ginger juice — "fanqie/ganzhe yin" pattern for nausea and dry vomiting in pregnancy/illness (small ginger amount)
- + water chestnut juice — summer heat and dysentery
- + pear juice — lung-dry cough

Cautions & incompatibilities

Cold and very sweet — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold with loose stools and vomiting cold patterns avoid; diabetes strict caution (pure sugar); **moldy/red-streaked sugarcane is acutely toxic (3-nitropropionic acid) — never eat cane with red/brown discoloration or off taste**; chew fiber carefully (dental).

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: heat thirst, autumn dryness, post-fever, hangover. **Avoid/reduce:** cold loose stools, diabetes, moldy cane (toxic).

White Mushroom

蘑菇

White Cool · Sweet Stomach · Lung · Spleen

Effects

- Fortifies the spleen and generates fluids (健脾开胃)
- Resolves toxin and transforms phlegm; stops vomiting/diarrhea (harmonizing)
- Nourishes without greasiness; modern immune support

Indications

Spleen weakness with poor appetite and fatigue; vomiting and diarrhea; phlegm dryness; post-illness convalescence; modern lipid/immune support.

Beneficial pairings

- + chicken soup — post-illness qi tonic
- + greens (rape) — blood stasis and constipation
- + tofu — meatless spleen tonic

Cautions & incompatibilities

Cool — very cold stomachs cook; "hair-raising food" (发物) caution for severe skin disease/allergy history; only eat cultivated identified mushrooms (wild-picking poisoning is fatal); purines moderate in gout; cook well.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: poor appetite, post-illness, general nourishment. **Avoid/reduce:** wild/unidentified fungi (never), gout excess, mushroom allergy.

Potato

马铃薯

White Neutral · Sweet Stomach · Large Intestine

Effects

- Tonifies qi and fortifies the spleen (益气健脾) — staple-like nourishment
- Detoxifies and reduces inflammation; raw juice soothes gastric mucosa (folk)
- Lubricates the intestines to move the bowels

Indications

Spleen-stomach weakness with poor appetite and fatigue; gastric ulcer/dyspepsia adjunct (raw juice folk use); chronic constipation; scald/skin inflammation external (slices); weight-neutral staple.

Beneficial pairings

- + beef stew — qi-blood deficiency weakness
- + green pepper (tudou si) — qi stagnation bloating
- Steamed, plain — gastric-mucosa friendly staple

Cautions & incompatibilities

Green/sprouted potatoes contain solanine — toxic; discard green/sprouted tubers. Starchy — diabetes counts as staple; fried preparation harms health; folk caution with banana (freckle/spot lore not substantiated); gas for some.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: weak digestion, general staple, ulcers (plain steamed). **Avoid/reduce:** green/sprouted tubers (toxic), fried excess, diabetes (staple count).

Garlic

大蒜

White Warm · Pungent Spleen · Stomach · Lung · Large Intestine

Effects

- Warms the middle and moves qi (温中消食); resolves food stagnation
- Detoxifies and kills parasites/intestinal worms (解毒杀虫) — used for dysentery and food poisoning patterns
- Reduces swelling and abscesses; modern: antimicrobial, lipid and cardiovascular support (allicin)

Indications

Cold-damp diarrhea and bacillary dysentery (raw garlic); hookworm/roundworm support; cold-stomach abdominal pain and bloating; whooping cough; carbuncles and scabies (external); winter epidemic prevention folk use; hyperlipidemia.

Beneficial pairings

- + cucumber/cold salads — offsets coldness and guards digestive upsets
- Raw garlic + warm water — dysentery and food poisoning patterns
- + vinegar-soaked garlic — hypertension/lipids and flu season (folk)

Cautions & incompatibilities

Pungent and warm — avoid/reduce in yin-deficiency heat, mouth ulcers, sore throat, stomach ulcer/eye disease/hemorrhoids, and after surgery; raw garlic irritates mucosa and skin (blistering) — external use caution; not with honey per food-therapy records; bad breath; anemia? folklore only. Moderate anticoagulant interaction note.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: cold-damp, dysentery, food poisoning patterns, flu season, lipids.

Avoid/reduce: ulcers, heat signs, eye disease, hemorrhoids, skin external misuse.

Yellow

Loquat

枇杷

Yellow Cool · Sweet, slightly sour Lung · Stomach

Effects

- Moistens the lung and stops cough (润肺止咳) — the leaf (枇杷叶) is the stronger medicine
- Descends qi and stops vomiting (降逆止呕); generates fluids
- Clears stomach heat; relieves irritability and thirst

Indications

Lung-dry/lung-heat cough, whooping-type cough, sore throat; stomach-heat nausea, vomiting and hiccup; summerheat thirst; the leaf (brushed clean, decocted) for cough and vomiting.

Beneficial pairings

- + pear + rock sugar, stewed — lung-dry cough
- Loquat leaf + reed root (芦根) — stomach-heat vomiting
- + honey — dry throat and cough

Cautions & incompatibilities

Cool — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold with loose stools eat small amounts/cooked; the pit contains cyanogenic glycosides — do not eat the kernel raw; fruit acid irritates ulcers; leaves must be brushed free of hairs (irritant) before decocting.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: lung-heat/dry cough, nausea, sore throat. **Avoid/reduce:** cold-stomach loose stools; never eat raw kernel.

Cantaloupe

哈密瓜

Yellow Cold · Sweet Heart · Stomach

Effects

- Clears summerheat and generates fluids (清暑生津)
- Relieves irritability and thirst; promotes urination
- Nourishes stomach yin; mildly laxative

Indications

Summerheat stroke with intense thirst; heat-damaged fluids with dry mouth; heat-type urinary difficulty and constipation; post-fever irritability; mouth sores.

Beneficial pairings

- + watermelon — intense summer heat
- Chilled lightly with yogurt (note cold burden) — heat constipation

Cautions & incompatibilities

Cold and very sweet — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold, loose stools, postpartum and the frail avoid excess; diabetes strict portion control (high sugar); canker-sore tendency moderate; bloating with other melons.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: summerheat, heat thirst, dry stools. **Avoid/reduce:** cold stomach/loose stools, diabetes, postpartum.

Pineapple

菠萝

Yellow Neutral (cool) · Sweet, slightly sour Stomach · Intestine

Effects

- Generates fluids and resolves summerheat (生津止渴)
- Fortifies the stomach and resolves food stagnation (健胃消食) — bromelain digests protein
- Moves qi and stops diarrhea patterns; resolves alcohol toxin

Indications

Food stagnation after heavy meat meals; poor appetite and indigestion; summerheat thirst with low-grade fever; mild diarrhea/dysentery; hangover; post-meal greasiness.

Beneficial pairings

- Soaked in light salt water before eating — reduces irritation (standard practice)
- + lean pork, cooked (菠萝咕咾肉) — protein digestion, appetite
- + honey — bronchitis cough (folk)

Cautions & incompatibilities

Bromelain can cause "pineapple mouth" irritation/allergic swelling — soak in salt water, and allergy-prone people avoid; ulcers and hyperacidity moderate (acid); kidney disease and ulcer history caution; very cold stomachs eat cooked/small amounts.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: meat stagnation, poor appetite, summer heat. **Avoid/reduce:** pineapple allergy, gastric ulcers, cold stomach excess.

Pomelo

柚子

Yellow Cold · Sweet, sour Spleen · Stomach · Lung · Liver

Effects

- Fortifies the stomach and moves qi (健胃消食) — resolves bloating
- Transforms phlegm and stops cough; descends qi
- Clears liver heat; relieves alcohol toxin; modern lipid/weight support

Indications

Food stagnation with bloating and belching; phlegm cough with chest oppression; poor appetite; hangover; hyperlipidemia and weight management; diabetes (low glycemic).

Beneficial pairings

- Pomelo peel (化橘红 adjacent) + old chicken — phlegm-damp cough and bloating
- + honey — cough and constipation
- Eaten after rich meals — greasy stagnation

Cautions & incompatibilities

Cold — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold with loose stools moderate; **drug interaction: pomelo/grapefruit furanocoumarins inhibit CYP3A4 — check with pharmacist for statins, calcium-channel blockers, sedatives;** diarrhea avoid; food-therapy records flag pomelo + certain blood-pressure medicines.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: phlegm-damp, overeating, lipids, diabetes (low GI). **Avoid/reduce:** cold diarrhea; interacting medications.

Star Fruit

杨桃

Yellow/Green Cold · Sweet, sour Lung · Stomach · Bladder

Effects

- Clears heat and generates fluids (清热生津)
- Moves water and relieves strangury (利水利尿); reduces edema
- Transforms phlegm; resolves alcohol and toxin

Indications

Wind-heat cough with sore throat; summerheat thirst; heat-type urinary difficulty and stone support; edema; mouth ulcers; hangover.

Beneficial pairings

- + honey — wind-heat sore throat and cough

- Fresh juice + warm water — heat strangury

Cautions & incompatibilities

Kidney safety: star fruit contains caramboxin and high oxalate — people with kidney disease (even moderate impairment) and those on dialysis must avoid it; intoxication (hiccups, neurotoxicity) occurs. Cold nature — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold, loose stools moderate; eat ripe.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: wind-heat sore throat, heat edema/strangury (healthy kidneys).

Avoid/reduce: kidney disease (avoid entirely), cold stomach/loose stools.

Durian

榴莲

Yellow Hot · Sweet Liver · Kidney · Lung

Effects

- Tonifies qi and blood and warms the middle (理气化痰, 温补)
- Dispels cold and warms the uterus; strengthens the body
- Blood-nourishing folk use for cold-deficiency and postpartum

Indications

Cold-deficiency constitution: cold limbs and abdomen, cold dysmenorrhea; post-illness/postpartum weakness with cold patterns; cold-type low back pain; the "king of fruits" winter warming tonic for cold types.

Beneficial pairings

- Eaten with mangosteen (the "queen of fruits") — the cooling fruit offsets durian's heat (classic Southeast Asian balance)
- With durian husk + salt water rinse/decoction — reduces heat symptoms
- + mung bean soup — counters durian "heat" (民间)

Cautions & incompatibilities

Very hot and greasy/cloying — strongly generates internal heat: avoid in yin-deficiency heat, sore throat, mouth ulcers, hypertension, diabetes (high sugar/fat), obesity, and during fever/colds; moderation is essential; not with alcohol (double heat burden); bloating in excess; heat constitutions eat sparingly with mangosteen or mung bean.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: cold-deficiency, cold dysmenorrhea, postpartum cold patterns (small amounts). **Avoid/reduce:** any heat sign, hypertension, diabetes, obesity, fever.

Orange

柳橙

Yellow Cool · Sweet, slightly sour Lung · Stomach · Liver

Effects

- Generates fluids and quenches thirst (生津止渴)
- Moves qi and resolves phlegm (理气化痰) — peel and pith are the active part
- Fortifies the spleen and opens appetite; relieves alcohol toxin

Indications

Wind-heat/summerheat dry throat and thirst; phlegm cough with chest fullness; poor appetite; bloating after meals; hangover; early wind-heat cold with heat signs.

Beneficial pairings

- + salt (steamed orange with a little salt) — heat-type cough (popular remedy)
- Orange peel (陈皮 aged tangerine peel) — the true qi-moving digestive medicine
- + ginger — mild nausea

Cautions & incompatibilities

Cool and acidic — wind-cold cough with clear white sputum avoid raw; ulcers/hyperacidity moderate; excessive raw juice on empty stomach irritates; the white pith is beneficial (retains qi-moving action); drug interaction note similar to grapefruit but weaker; dental acid erosion — rinse.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: heat-type cough/thirst, phlegm-bloating, hangover. **Avoid/reduce:** wind-cold cough, ulcers excess, empty-stomach raw juice.

Tangerine

橘子

Yellow/Orange Warm · Sweet, sour Lung · Stomach

Effects

- Moistens the lung and generates fluids (润肺生津)
- Moves qi and harmonizes the stomach (理气和中); resolves phlegm
- The dried aged peel (陈皮 chénpí) is a prime digestive medicine; the pith network (橘络) moves qi and resolves phlegm

Indications

Dry cough and throat dryness; bloating and poor appetite; chest oppression with phlegm; vomiting and hiccup; "chenpi" for phlegm-damp and food stagnation; qi stagnation.

Beneficial pairings

- Aged tangerine peel + rice congee — bloating and phlegm-damp (classic)
- Chenpi + hawthorn — food stagnation
- + ginger — cold vomiting and nausea

Cautions & incompatibilities

Fresh fruit is warm and cloying — excess generates phlegm-heat, mouth ulcers and "internal heat" (orange-induced dry mouth); eat the pith to reduce this; yin-deficiency heat, phlegm cough with yellow sputum in fever moderate; diabetes portion control; wind-cold? fresh warm fruit is acceptable small amounts.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: qi stagnation bloating, phlegm (aged peel), mild dry cough. **Avoid/reduce:** phlegm-heat/sores excess, diabetes; fresh fruit in excess.

Apricot

杏

Yellow Warm · Sweet, sour (flesh); Bitter (kernel) Lung · Large Intestine

Effects

- Flesh: moistens the lung and stops cough (润肺止咳); generates fluids
- The seed (杏仁 xìngrén) descends lung qi to stop cough/wheeze and lubricates the intestines
- Sweet apricot kernel is food-grade; bitter kernel is a regulated medicine

Indications

Dry cough and thirst (fresh fruit); lung-dry chronic cough and constipation of the elderly (sweet kernel with walnut/honey); wheeze with dry stools.

Beneficial pairings

- Sweet apricot kernel + walnut + honey — elderly dry constipation and chronic dry cough
- + pear stewed — autumn dry cough
- Dried apricot + white fungus — lung-moistening soup

Cautions & incompatibilities

Bitter apricot kernels contain amygdalin → cyanide poisoning in quantity; never eat raw bitter kernels (children especially; a few can be fatal); use sweet kernels in food. Flesh is warm — excess produces heat, mouth sores and diarrhea ("杏子吃多伤身"); pregnant women and infants caution with kernels.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: dry cough, dry constipation (sweet kernel), autumn lung dryness.
Avoid/reduce: raw bitter kernels (toxic), heat signs, fresh fruit in excess.

Longan / Dragon's Eye

龙眼 / 桂圆

Yellow Warm · Sweet Heart · Spleen

Effects

- Tonifies the heart and spleen (补益心脾) — top food for heart-spleen deficiency
- Nourishes blood and calms the spirit (养血安神)
- Augments qi; strengthens the intellect and memory

Indications

Heart-spleen deficiency: overthinking, palpitations, insomnia, forgetfulness, dream-disturbed sleep; qi-blood deficiency after childbirth or illness; fatigue, sallow face; postpartum edema and qi deficiency.

Beneficial pairings

- + red jujube + lotus seed — insomnia, forgetfulness and palpitations (classic)
- Dried longan + glutinous rice congee — postpartum qi-blood deficiency
- + ginseng/astragalus congee — severe qi deficiency with sweating

Cautions & incompatibilities

Warm and very sweet — strongly generates heat and phlegm: avoid in yin-deficiency heat, heat constitutions, phlegm-fire, mouth ulcers, sore throat, during fever/colds, diabetes, and pregnancy with heat signs; excess can cause "longan fire" (nosebleed, constipation); children moderate.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: heart-spleen deficiency insomnia, anemia, postpartum/overthinking fatigue.
Avoid/reduce: heat signs, diabetes, phlegm-fire, febrile illness.

Kumquat

金桔

Yellow Warm · Pungent, sweet, sour Liver · Lung · Spleen · Stomach

Effects

- Moves qi and resolves depression/stagnation (理气解郁) — soothes liver qi
- Resolves phlegm and benefits the throat (化痰利咽); relieves the chest
- Fortifies digestion; reduces alcohol toxin

Indications

Qi stagnation with chest/hypochondriac fullness, belching and poor appetite (stress digestion); phlegm cough and sore throat; hangover; candied kumquat for chronic bronchitis; early cold.

Beneficial pairings

- Candied kumquat (糖渍金橘) steeped as tea — chronic phlegm cough and sore throat
- + ginger + brown sugar — wind-cold early cold with cough
- + rock sugar, stewed — children's cough and bloating

Cautions & incompatibilities

Warm pungent — heat constitutions, mouth ulcers and yin-deficiency dry cough moderate; diabetic candied versions caution; eat the peel (where pungent qi-moving oils reside); excess may irritate ulcers.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: stress/qi-stagnation bloating, phlegm cough, hangover. **Avoid/reduce:** heat signs, diabetes (candied), ulcers excess.

Mango

芒果

Yellow Cool (neutral) · Sweet, sour Lung · Spleen · Stomach

Effects

- Generates fluids and relieves thirst (生津止渴)
- Fortifies the stomach and stops vomiting (益胃止呕); mango is a classic motion-sickness food
- Moves urine; moistens the lung; the kernel (芒果核) is used for hernia and dysentery in folk medicine

Indications

Motion sickness and morning nausea; thirst and dry throat; poor appetite; heat-type urinary difficulty; chronic cough with dry throat; the peel/leaf for eczema (external folk).

Beneficial pairings

- Eaten before travel — motion sickness nausea
- + honey — dry throat and constipation

Cautions & incompatibilities

A classic "fatty/hair-raising" food (发物) — mango dermatitis/allergic contact around the lips is common (peel, avoid skin contact; allergy-prone and young children caution);

damp-heat and skin disease (eczema, acne, boils) avoid; diabetes high sugar; mango kernel is not eaten casually.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: nausea/motion sickness, dry throat, low appetite. **Avoid/reduce:** mango allergy, damp-heat skin conditions, diabetes.

Lemon

柠檬

Yellow Neutral (cool) · Sour, slightly bitter Lung · Stomach

Effects

- Generates fluids and relieves summerheat (生津祛暑)
- Harmonizes the stomach and relieves nausea; relieves alcohol toxin
- Aids anchoring qi and resolving phlegm; vitamin-C rich for cold support

Indications

Summerheat thirst and irritability; heat-stroke and hangover; poor appetite with dry mouth; early cold with sore throat; greasy-meal stagnation; motion sickness.

Beneficial pairings

- + honey, warm water — dry throat, constipation and beauty tonic
- + salt water — sore throat gargle; early cold
- Juice over fish/rich meals — cuts grease, aids digestion

Cautions & incompatibilities

Very sour — gastric/duodenal ulcers, hyperacidity and reflux avoid on empty stomach; dental enamel erosion (drink diluted, rinse); do not steep in boiling water (destroys vitamin C); kidney stones? citrate is actually favorable; cold stomachs use warm water and small amounts.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: summer thirst, hangover, greasy meals, cold support. **Avoid/reduce:** ulcers/hyperacidity, empty-stomach undiluted juice.

Papaya

木瓜

Yellow Warm · Sweet Liver · Spleen · Stomach

Effects

- Fortifies the spleen and aids digestion (健脾消食) — papain digests protein; classic for meat stagnation

- Disperses wind-damp and relaxes the sinews (舒筋活络)
- Reduces swelling, promotes lactation; harmonizes the stomach

Indications

Indigestion and bloating, especially after meat/protein meals; stomach pain from food stagnation; wind-damp limb pain and cramping; blocked lactation; summer damp-heat with poor appetite.

Beneficial pairings

- + lean pork/ribs stew (木瓜排骨汤) — digestion and lactation
- + pig's trotter — blocked lactation (folk)
- Raw ripe papaya after meals — protein stagnation

Cautions & incompatibilities

Warm — pregnancy: large amounts of unripe papaya contain latex/papain that may stimulate contractions (avoid unripe papaya medicinally); heat constitutions and yellow-urine heat patterns moderate; papain allergy possible; very unripe harsh latex irritates.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: meat stagnation, weak digestion, blocked lactation, wind-damp.

Avoid/reduce: pregnancy (unripe/large amounts), excess heat patterns.

Passion Fruit

百香果

Yellow/Purple Neutral · Sweet, sour Lung · Stomach · Large Intestine

Effects

- Clears heat and generates fluids (清热生津)
- Moistens the lung and transforms phlegm; soothes the throat
- Lubricates the intestines; calms the spirit (seeds rich in calming oils, folk)

Indications

Heat-type cough and sore throat; dry constipation and gut sluggishness; thirst and poor appetite; stress-related insomnia (calming folk use); modern weight management and vitamin support.

Beneficial pairings

- + honey, warm water — cough, constipation and sleep support
- + yogurt — constipation and gut health
- Fruit tea — summer heat and appetite

Cautions & incompatibilities

Sour — gastric ulcers and hyperacidity moderate; sensitive seeds for diverticulitis (folk, rarely significant); cold stomachs use warm water; diabetes portions.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: heat cough/sore throat, constipation, stress sleep. **Avoid/reduce:** ulcers/acid excess, cold stomach excess.

Pumpkin

南瓜

Yellow Warm · Sweet Spleen · Stomach · Lung

Effects

- Tonifies the middle and fortifies qi (补中益气) — premier spleen-stomach tonic vegetable
- Anti-inflammatory/detoxifies; the seed (南瓜子) expels parasites and benefits the prostate
- Warms the lung and resolves phlegm-cold

Indications

Spleen-stomach weakness with poor appetite, fatigue, loose stools; qi deficiency after illness; lung-cold cough with abundant white sputum; burns (pulp external, folk); intestinal parasites (seeds); modern diabetes adjunct (moderate) and prostate support (seed).

Beneficial pairings

- + millet congee (南瓜小米粥) — spleen deficiency and post-illness nourishment
- + red jujube — qi-blood deficiency
- Pumpkin seeds, ground — parasites (folk) and zinc/prostate nutrition

Cautions & incompatibilities

Warm and sweet — generates dampness and bloating in excess; fullness/qi stagnation and jaundice-damp-heat moderate; diabetes counts as staple (carbs); very large daily intake can cause benign carotenemia; only eat fresh pumpkin — rotted pumpkin toxic. Folk incompatibility with mutton (both warm) — heat signs caution.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: spleen-stomach weakness, qi deficiency, cold cough, elderly/children.

Avoid/reduce: damp-heat/jaundice, bloating, diabetes (staple count), rotted fruit.

Daylily Buds (Golden Needles)

金针菜 / 黄花菜

Yellow Neutral · Sweet Liver · Kidney · Large Intestine

Effects

- Nourishes blood and pacifies the liver (养血平肝) — soothes irritability
- Clears heat and benefits the urine; reduces swelling; lactation support
- Calms the spirit and brightens the eyes (安神明目) — called "the calming vegetable"

Indications

Blood deficiency with insomnia, irritability and depression; liver-heat redness of eyes; urinary bleeding/stranguria; insufficient lactation; bloody stools; modern menopausal and stress support.

Beneficial pairings

- + black fungus (金针木耳) — blood-nourishing, cardiovascular support (classic)
- + pork rib/pig trotter soup — blocked lactation
- + egg soup — insomnia and irritability

Cautions & incompatibilities

Safety: fresh daylily flowers contain colchicine — toxic raw (converts to colchicine in the body); use dried flowers or blanch/boil fresh flowers thoroughly. Fibrous/qi-moving — loose stools moderate; not for cold stomach in large amounts raw.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for (dried/cooked): insomnia/irritability, lactation support, blood deficiency.
Avoid/reduce: raw fresh flowers (toxic), cold loose stools excess.

Ginger

生姜

Yellow Warm · Pungent Lung · Spleen · Stomach

Effects

- Induces sweating to release the exterior (发汗解表) — first food for wind-cold
- Warms the middle and stops vomiting (温中止呕) — "the sage of vomiting medicines" (呕家圣药)
- Warms the lung to stop cough; detoxifies fish-crab toxin

Indications

Early wind-cold common cold with chills, no sweat, clear runny nose; cold-stomach pain, nausea and vomiting (including motion and pregnancy nausea); cold-phlegm cough with white sputum; antidote to seafood/fish poisoning; appetite in cold damp.

Beneficial pairings

- **Ginger + brown sugar (姜糖水)** — the classic wind-cold cold and cold-stomach pain remedy
- + scallion white (葱白) — early cold with no sweat
- + garlic — cold-damp dysentery; with seafood — detoxifies and warms
- Ginger peel (姜皮) — water/edema (cooling, diuretic)

Cautions & incompatibilities

Warm pungent — contraindicated in heat patterns: yin-deficiency heat, high fever, sore throat, mouth ulcers, nosebleed, eye inflammation, hemorrhoids, hepatitis with heat, and night sweats; do not use long-term in large amounts; rotten ginger contains safrole/liver-toxic compounds — discard; diabetes brown sugar portions.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: wind-cold cold, cold-stomach pain/vomiting, seafood meals, cold constitutions. **Avoid/reduce:** heat signs, fever, sore throat, yin deficiency; rotten ginger never.

Black/Purple

Grape

葡萄

Black/Purple Neutral · Sweet, sour Lung · Spleen · Kidney

Effects

- Tonifies qi and blood (补气血) — one of the blood-nourishing fruits
- Strengthens the sinews and bones; benefits urination
- Nourishes liver-kidney yin; raisins/wine warming for weak constitutions

Indications

Qi-blood deficiency with fatigue, pallor and palpitations; liver-kidney deficiency with weak sore lower back/knees; poor appetite in summer; palpitations and insomnia; raisins for weakness; mild edema with urination difficulty.

Beneficial pairings

- + honey — blood deficiency and post-illness thirst
- Raisins + red jujube congee — anemia and fatigue
- Grape wine (small) — cold limbs and bi-pain of the elderly

Cautions & incompatibilities

Sweet and cloying — damp-heat with diarrhea, phlegm, fullness and obesity moderate; diabetes portion control (sugar high, especially raisins); grape wine adds heat — heat signs avoid; wash thoroughly.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: qi-blood deficiency, weak back/knees, convalescence, anemia.

Avoid/reduce: damp diarrhea, diabetes (raisins), phlegm-heat.

Mulberry

桑葚

Black/Purple Cold · Sweet, sour Heart · Liver · Kidney

Effects

- Nourishes yin and blood (滋阴养血) — premier black blood/yin tonic
- Generates fluids and moistens the intestines; blackens hair
- Tonifies liver-kidney; modern iron/antioxidant support

Indications

Liver-kidney yin-blood deficiency: dizziness, tinnitus, premature graying, sore weak back/knees, insomnia; yin-deficiency diabetes thirst; dry constipation; post-illness anemia; menopausal yin deficiency with heat.

Beneficial pairings

- + black sesame + walnut — graying, dizziness and constipation (classic)
- + honey — yin-deficiency constipation
- + longan/red jujube — anemia and insomnia

Cautions & incompatibilities

Cold and moistening — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold with loose stools avoid excess; diabetes dried/syrup versions caution; stains; unripe fruit is sour-puckering; moderate bloating.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: yin-blood deficiency, graying/dizziness, dry constipation, menopause.

Avoid/reduce: cold loose stools, yang deficiency excess.

Mangosteen

山竹

Black/Purple Cool · Sweet, slightly sour Spleen · Lung

Effects

- Clears heat and cools fire (清热降火) — the "queen of fruits" balances durian
- Moistens the lung and generates fluids
- Resolves toxins; cools skin heat

Indications

Internal heat: mouth ulcers, sore throat, acne, dry stool; after eating durian/lychee-type hot fruits; summerheat thirst; fever recovery.

Beneficial pairings

- Eaten with durian — counteracts durian's heat (classic)
- + watermelon — summer heat

Cautions & incompatibilities

Very cooling — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold, loose stools and the frail/yang-deficient eat sparingly; excess causes diarrhea and abdominal cold pain; kidney disease moderate potassium; diabetes moderate sugar.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: heat constitutions, after hot fruits, mouth ulcers/acne. **Avoid/reduce:** cold stomach/loose stools, yang deficiency.

Eggplant

茄子

Black/Purple Cool · Sweet Spleen · Stomach · Large Intestine

Effects

- Clears heat and cools blood (清热凉血)
- Resolves toxin and reduces swelling; disperses blood stasis
- Moistens the intestines; modern cardiovascular/cholesterol support (nasunin in skin)

Indications

Heat-type hemorrhoid bleeding and constipation; blood-heat nosebleed; sores, carbuncles and breast swelling (external); summer heat sores; hyperlipidemia/cardiovascular support.

Beneficial pairings

- + garlic braised (蒜香茄子) — offsets coolness; blood stasis/cardiovascular
- + black fungus — cardiovascular and blood-vessel support (classic)
- Steamed + soy/vinegar dressing — heat hemorrhoids and weight care

Cautions & incompatibilities

Cool and slippery — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold, chronic loose stools and asthma of the cold type moderate (cook with ginger/garlic, avoid cold raw eggplant); **eat cooked, not raw (solanine in raw/overripe eggplant)**; it absorbs frying oil massively — prefer steaming/stewing; pre-surgery? folklore.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: hemorrhoid bleeding/constipation, heat patterns, lipids/cardio.

Avoid/reduce: cold loose stools (cook hot), raw fruit.

Plum

李子

Black/Purple Neutral · Sweet, sour Liver · Kidney

Effects

- Clears liver heat and generates fluids (清肝热、生津液)
- Moves water; relieves ascites/edema and urinary difficulty
- The kernels (李仁, yuliren-like) lubricate intestines; resolves toxin

Indications

Liver yin-deficiency with internal heat: dry mouth and thirst, steam-bone fever; ascites/edema with scanty urine; chronic constipation (kernels); cirrhosis-adjunct folk use; summer poor appetite.

Beneficial pairings

- + honey — liver heat and constipation
- + lemon juice — summer thirst and appetite

Cautions & incompatibilities

Over-ripe/excess plums damage the spleen-stomach — sour plum excess causes bloating, phlegm, and teeth erosion ("桃养人杏伤人, 李子树下拾死人" is folklore caution against excess); ulcers/hyperacidity moderate; diarrhea caution; kernels medicinal only (amygdalin).

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: liver heat with thirst, ascites/edema, constipation. **Avoid/reduce:** excess (bloating/damage), ulcers/acid, weak digestion.

Purple Cabbage

紫甘蓝

Black/Purple Neutral (cool) · Sweet Stomach · Kidney

Effects

- Nourishes the stomach and benefits the joints (利关节)
- Clears heat and resolves pain; promotes urination
- Modern: anthocyanin antioxidant and gastric-protective support

Indications

Gastric discomfort and ulcers adjunct (vitamin U-like support); joint discomfort; summer heat and thirst; constipation; modern cardiovascular and immune support.

Beneficial pairings

- + garlic/ginger dressing — offsets coolness; blood health
- + wood-ear mushroom — cardiovascular support
- Lightly stir-fried — preserves nutrients for cold constitutions

Cautions & incompatibilities

Cool raw salads — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold with loose stools and chronic enteritis should stir-fry/moderate; goitrogens negligible with normal iodine; thyroid and iodine-deficiency cooking is adequate; gas-producing for IBS; very few major contraindications.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: gastric comfort adjunct, joint issues, general health. **Avoid/reduce:** cold stomach raw excess, IBS gas.

Mushroom

香菇

Black/Purple Neutral · Sweet Stomach · Liver

Effects

- Fortifies the spleen and stomach (健脾开胃)
- Nourishes qi and resolves phlegm; expels wind-rash
- Resolves toxin; modern immune and lipid support (lentinan)

Indications

Spleen-stomach weakness with fatigue and poor appetite; chronic qi deficiency with frequent illness; measles not expressing; smallpox-type rashes (folk); hyperlipidemia; convalescence; reduced immunity support.

Beneficial pairings

- + chicken stew — post-illness qi tonic and immunity (classic)
- + bok choy (油菜香菇) — qi and blood circulation
- + lean meat soup — weak appetite in children/elderly

Cautions & incompatibilities

A "fatty/hair-raising" food (发物) — severe skin disease, asthma flares and allergy-prone people moderate; purines moderate in gout; only cultivated/identified mushrooms; cook well; very damp-cold stomach pair with ginger.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: weak digestion, qi deficiency, convalescence, immune support.

Avoid/reduce: mushroom allergy, active skin disease, gout excess.

Water Caltrop

菱角

Black/Purple Neutral (cool) · Sweet Stomach · Large Intestine

Effects

- Tonifies qi and fortifies the spleen (益气健脾) — water-grain staple
- Anti-diabetic/diuretic; the shell (菱壳) resolves sores and nodules (folk anticancer lore)
- Relieves alcohol and heat toxin

Indications

Spleen deficiency with poor appetite, fatigue and loose stools; summerheat thirst and alcohol toxin; edema and scanty urination; modern diabetes and gastric health adjunct (well-cooked).

Beneficial pairings

- + glutinous rice congee — spleen deficiency and post-illness
- + pork rib stew — qi deficiency weakness
- Raw for heat (peeled); cooked for cold constitutions

Cautions & incompatibilities

Must be cooked: raw water caltrop can transmit Fasciolopsis (giant intestinal fluke) from contaminated water — boil/steam thoroughly. Raw is cooler; starchy — diabetes staple-count and excess bloating; spleen cold eat cooked.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for (cooked): spleen weakness, summer heat, diabetes adjunct. **Avoid/reduce:** raw contaminated fruit (parasites), bloating excess.

Black Fungus

黑木耳

Black/Purple Neutral · Sweet Stomach · Large Intestine

Effects

- Tonifies qi and blood; cools blood (益气凉血) — "the meat of the fields"
- Moves blood and unblocks stasis (活血) — softens vessels
- Moistens the lung, lubricates the intestines; resolves toxin; stone support

Indications

Blood stasis patterns: hypertension, cardiovascular/coronary support, thrombus prevention (folk), menstrual stasis pain; hemorrhoid bleeding; dry constipation; uterine bleeding; lung dryness; modern anemia and stone support.

Beneficial pairings

- + daylily buds (金针木耳) — blood-nourishing vascular support (classic)
- + red jujube, slow-simmered — anemia and sallowness (women's tonic)
- + celery — hypertension and lipids

Cautions & incompatibilities

Blood-activating and moistening — bleeding tendency, post-surgery, and chronic diarrhea caution; **anticoagulant medications: consult before large regular amounts;** pregnant women moderate; **never soak dried fungus longer than ~4 hours / overnight in warmth (Brettanomyces toxin poisonings) — soak in cold water shortly and fully cook;** thoroughly cook.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: blood stasis/cardiovascular, constipation, anemia. **Avoid/reduce:** bleeding disorders/anticoagulants (ask clinician), diarrhea, over-long soaked fungus.

Kelp

海带

Black/Purple Cold · Salty Liver · Stomach · Kidney

Effects

- Softens hardness and dissipates nodules (软坚散结) — salty seaweed classic for goiters/nodules
- Resolves phlegm and water; promotes urination to reduce edema
- Iodine-rich for thyroid function; modern lipid/weight support

Indications

Goiter and thyroid nodules from iodine deficiency; lymphatic nodules/scrofula; edema and ascites; hypertension, hyperlipidemia and coronary support; obesity with phlegm-dampness; testicular swelling.

Beneficial pairings

- + pork rib soup — nodules and edema; daily tonic
- + mung bean — summer heat and edema; thyroid heat
- + tofu (海带炖豆腐) — calcium/iodine balance (classic; the calcium-binding concern is overcooking only)

Cautions & incompatibilities

Thyroid caution: iodine-rich — hyperthyroidism and certain thyroiditis patients must avoid or strictly limit; autoimmune thyroid disease requires clinician guidance. Cold — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold and pregnant women moderate; very high purines/sodium — gout and hypertension soak-cook and moderate; soak to reduce arsenic/cadmium residues.

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: iodine-deficiency goiter/nodules, phlegm-damp edema, lipids/weight.

Avoid/reduce: hyperthyroidism, cold stomach, pregnancy moderate, gout/sodium-restricted diets.

Monk Fruit

罗汉果

Black/Brown Cool · Sweet Lung · Large Intestine

Effects

- Clears lung heat and moistens the lung (清热润肺) — the natural no-sugar sweetener for coughs
- Benefits the throat and resolves phlegm; relieves hoarseness
- Lubricates the intestines to move the bowels (滑肠通便)

Indications

Lung heat / lung-dry chronic cough, whooping-type cough; sore throat and hoarseness (teachers, smokers); heat-type constipation; diabetes and obesity (sweet but non-glycemic mogrosides); summerheat thirst.

Beneficial pairings

- Steeped as tea with a little dried fruit (罗汉果茶) — hoarse voice and chronic cough (classic)
- + lily bulb + snow fungus — lung-dry cough
- + chrysanthemum — heat sore throat and constipation

Cautions & incompatibilities

Cool — spleen-stomach deficiency-cold with loose stools and cold cough (clear white sputum) should moderate or avoid; one fruit is very sweet — a small piece suffices for tea; wind-cold acute cough not suited; very safe for diabetics (still whole-food moderation).

Suitable for / avoid in

Best for: chronic dry/heat cough, hoarseness, heat constipation, diabetics/weight care.

Avoid/reduce: cold loose stools, wind-cold cough.

Quick Reference Table

Symptom / condition	Pattern note	Recommended foods
Cough (lung dry/heat)	Dry throat, scant sticky sputum, autumn dryness	Pear (stewed + rock sugar), loquat, lily bulb, white radish, snow fungus, monk fruit, persimmon, water chestnut, pomelo, kumquat, fig
Cold / flu (wind-cold, early)	Chills, clear runny nose, no sweat	Ginger + brown sugar, scallion + ginger, cilantro, garlic, white radish + ginger, warm chicken soup
Constipation (dry/heat)	Dry stools, heat patterns	Banana, sweet potato, dragon fruit, Chinese yam (paired), kiwifruit, spinach, fig, mulberry + black sesame, snow fungus, bamboo shoots, winter melon, apple (raw), water chestnut
Indigestion / bloating / food stagnation	After greasy/meat meals	Hawthorn (with malt for meat stagnation), white radish, papaya, pineapple, aged tangerine peel (chenpi), kumquat, crown daisy greens, grapefruit, loquat
Insomnia / anxiety / palpitations	Heart-blood / yin deficiency, overthinking	Lily bulb + lotus seed, longan (cold types), red jujube, jujube + longan + lotus seed, daylily buds, crown daisy, lotus seed congee, passion fruit
Edema / water retention	Dampness, scanty urine	Winter melon (+ carp), corn silk, kelp, winter melon rind, bottle gourd, cucumber, coix + winter melon, coconut water, water caltrop
Qi deficiency / fatigue / weak digestion	Spleen deficiency, pale face, loose stools	Chinese yam, red jujube, potato, pumpkin, shiitake, rice congee + yam, lotus seed, chestnut, fig, cauliflower, shiitake + chicken
Blood deficiency / anemia	Dizziness, sallow face	Red jujube (+ black fungus), longan, mulberry, grapes/raisins, lotus root (cooked), spinach (+

		pork liver), black fungus + jujube, red jujube + longan
Summerheat / thirst / dehydration	High heat, scanty dark urine	Watermelon, mung bean soup, sugarcane juice, coconut water, muskmelon, bitter melon juice, cucumber, Hami melon, wumei/sour-plum drink
Sore throat / hoarseness	Heat or phlegm-heat	Chinese olive (+ radish juice), monk fruit tea, pear, loquat, strawberry, olive, steamed orange + salt, water chestnut
Hypertension / liver yang rising	Headache, dizziness, red face	Celery (+ tomato juice), black fungus, kelp, hawthorn tea, banana, eggplant, winter melon, spinach, crown daisy, purple cabbage
Kidney deficiency / low back & knees	Cold or yin deficiency of the root	Walnut, chestnut, black beans/black sesame (+ mulberry), chives (yang), grapes, lotus root (cooked), mulberry + walnut + sesame
Chronic diarrhea / loose stools (spleen deficiency)	Post-meal loose stool, cold types	Chinese yam (+ lotus seed + gorgon), steamed apple, pomegranate (astringent), wumei, coconut flesh, pumpkin + millet, chestnut congee (avoid the cold/lubricating foods listed above)
Blocked lactation	Postpartum milk insufficiency	Loofah (+ crucian carp), water bamboo + fish, papaya + trotter, daylily + trotter soup; ensure warm nourishing congee
Phlegm / dampness	Heaviness, greasy coat, lumps	White radish, kelp, winter melon, pomelo, tangerine peel (chenpi), orange, crown daisy, coix seed, shiitake

Nature	Foods
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Cold (~20)	Watermelon 西瓜, persimmon 柿子, grapefruit 葡萄柚, muskmelon 香瓜, kiwifruit 猕猴桃, bitter melon 苦瓜, banana 香蕉, water chestnut 荸荠, sugarcane 甘蔗, Hami melon 哈密瓜, star fruit 杨桃, pomelo 柚子, kelp 海带, mulberry 桑葚, lily bulb 百合, bamboo shoots 竹笋, water bamboo 茭白, water spinach 空心菜, bracken 蕨菜, napa cabbage 白菜
Cool (~21)	Strawberry 草莓, tomato 番茄, pear 梨, apple 苹果, dragon fruit 火龙果, loquat 枇杷, orange 柳橙, mango 芒果, mangosteen 山竹, monk fruit 罗汉果, eggplant 茄子, cucumber 黄瓜, loofah 丝瓜, bottle gourd 瓠瓜, winter melon 冬瓜, button mushroom 蘑菇, spinach 菠菜, celery 芹菜, amaranth greens 苋菜, rape/bok choy greens 油菜, purple cabbage 紫甘蓝
Neutral (~26)	Sweet potato 红薯, carrot 胡萝卜, Chinese toon shoots 香椿, crown daisy greens 茼蒿, Chinese olive 橄榄, smoked plum/wumei 乌梅, fig 无花果, ginkgo nut 银杏, lotus seed 莲子, lotus root 莲藕 (cooked), coconut 椰子 (flesh), cauliflower 菜花, Chinese yam 山药, snow fungus 银耳, taro 芋头, potato 马铃薯, lemon 柠檬, pineapple 菠萝, passion fruit 百香果, pumpkin 南瓜 (slightly warm), daylily buds 金针菜, grape 葡萄, plum 李子, shiitake 香菇, water caltrop 菱角, black fungus 黑木耳
Warm (~21)	Red jujube 红枣, hawthorn 山楂 (slightly warm), waxberry/bayberry 杨梅, peach 桃子, cherry 樱桃, lychee 荔枝, pomegranate 石榴, cilantro 香菜, green pepper 青椒, Chinese chives 韭菜, walnut 核桃, chestnut 栗子, white radish 白萝卜 (cool-pungent), garlic 大蒜, onion 洋葱, tangerine 橘子, apricot 杏, longan 龙眼, kumquat 金橘, papaya 木瓜, fresh ginger 生姜
Hot (~2)	Chili pepper 辣椒, durian 榴莲 — the hottest foods in this set; use sparingly and avoid with any heat signs (mouth ulcers, sore throat, constipation, hypertension)

Note: classifications follow standard dietotherapy references and vary slightly by source and preparation (cooking generally reduces coldness); raw vs. cooked nature differs for lotus root, apples, ginger peel and several melons. Match thermal nature to the person's constitution and presenting pattern rather than applying labels rigidly.